

How Does Public Activism Shape Voluntary Disclosure?

Evidence from the Thematic Contents of Conference Calls *

Jiamin Zhao[†]

March 2026

I examine whether public activism (PA) shapes firms' voluntary disclosure in earnings conference calls. Linking more than 170,000 U.S. street protest events during 2017–2023 to approximately 46,000 firm-quarter conference calls, I find that firms exposed to nearby activism make disclosure more selective. On average, exposed firms provide less informative content, use less negative language, and reallocate discussion away from attention-sensitive topics and toward relatively safer strategic narratives. These effects are concentrated in prepared remarks, where managerial discretion is greatest, and are stronger when activism participation is higher. Cross-sectional tests show that the response varies by activism type: ESG-oriented activism is associated with a clearer shift away from financial and expansion-related topics, whereas finance-related activism is associated with greater emphasis on performance-related discussion. A rainfall-based instrumental-variables design yields results consistent with a causal interpretation. Overall, the evidence suggests that public activism affects not only firms' operating environment, but also their disclosure environment, leading managers to adjust both the informativeness and composition of conference-call communication.

Keywords: public activism, conference call, thematic composition, voluntary disclosure.

JEL Classification: M41, D83, G14, M14

*This paper is part of my Ph.D. dissertation. I sincerely thank my advisors, Igor Kadach and Gaizka Ormazabal, for their invaluable guidance, and the Accounting Department and Ph.D. Program at IESE for their ongoing support. I am grateful to my fellow Ph.D. students Guillermo Ramirez-Chiang, Yiwei Zhang, and Long Chen at IESE for their generous assistance, as well as helpful comments from Martin Jacob, Frank Wijen, Ilan Guttman, Donald N'Gatta, Pietro Bonetti, Luzi Hail, and participants at the BS4CL 3rd Conference (HEC Paris), the 2025 IE Doctoral Consortium (IE Business School, Madrid), the VIII ERC Conference (Università degli Studi di Napoli Federico II, Naples), the XIX International Accounting Research Symposium (UC3M, Madrid) and the Swiss Doctoral Program Network (UZH, Zurich).

[†]IESE Business School, Department of Accounting, 08034 Barcelona, Spain. E-mail: JZhao@iese.edu.

1 Introduction

Public activism (PA), broadly defined as collective action by individuals or groups without formal institutional power to address perceived social problems, has become a prominent feature of firms’ external environment (Briscoe and Gupta, 2016). In this paper, I focus on public manifestations of activism such as protests, rallies, and demonstrations in the United States. The scale of such activity is substantial. The Crowd Counting Consortium records more than 170,000 protest events between 2017 and 2023, spanning issues such as environmental protection, racial justice, immigration, and economic inequality (Figure Figure 1). Through these activities, non-shareholder stakeholders seek to influence corporate behavior, public policy, and broader social norms.

[Figure 1 about here.]

Prior research shows that public activism has important consequences for political outcomes, regulation, financial markets, and corporate behavior (Acemoglu and Robinson, 2000; Madestam, Shoag, Veuger, and Yanagizawa-Drott, 2013; McDonnell and King, 2013; Zhang, Briscoe, and DesJardine, 2023; Barrett, Bondar, Chen, Chivakul, and Igan, 2024). Much less is known, however, about whether PA affects managers’ voluntary disclosure choices. This question is relevant because managerial disclosure is one of the primary channels through which firms respond to changes in their external information environment, with potentially important implications for investor beliefs and capital allocation.

In this paper, I examine whether public activism in the vicinity of a firm’s headquarters affects managerial disclosure in earnings conference calls. Public activism differs from many other forces studied in the disclosure literature because it originates from non-shareholder stakeholders whose objectives often extend beyond firms’ short-term financial performance (Freeman, 2010). Relative to investors, these stakeholders are more likely to emphasize non-financial concerns, including environmental, social, and governance issues (Konwar, Wei, Wood, and Eng-Tuck Cheah, 2024; Ormazábal, 2018). Moreover, unlike shareholders, who

possess formal governance rights and can influence firms *ex ante* (Shleifer and Vishny, 1986; Gillan and Starks, 2000; Brav, Jiang, Partnoy, and Thomas, 2008) non-shareholder stakeholders often affect firms *ex post* by imposing external scrutiny, reputational, or operating costs when firms are perceived as unresponsive to salient public concerns (McDonnell and King, 2013). These features make public activism a potentially important driver of a shift in the composition of disclosure topics because it can affect both the demand for corporate information and the expected cost of certain public statements.

My central argument is that nearby PA can affect conference-call disclosure through two related channels. First, PA can operate as an economic shock by disrupting local operations and increasing uncertainty about firm fundamentals, thereby increasing investor demand for timely clarification.¹ Second, PA can operate as an information and scrutiny shock by making stakeholder concerns more salient and increasing the expected cost of public statements that may later be challenged or reinterpreted. Accordingly, public activism need not lead firms to disclose uniformly more or less. Instead, it can change the thematic content of conference-call disclosure by affecting how much information managers convey, which topics they emphasize, and how they frame their remarks. This logic fits naturally within the voluntary disclosure literature, which views disclosure as a tradeoff between benefits, such as reducing information asymmetry, and costs, such as litigation, proprietary, and other disclosure-related frictions (Dye, 1985; Healy and Palepu, 2001; Verrecchia, 1983; Leuz and Wysocki, 2016). Conceptually, the paper shows that public activism affects not only firms' real environment, but also the benefits and expected scrutiny costs of voluntary disclosure, thereby changing the thematic content of conference-call communication.

Earnings conference calls provide a particularly suitable setting for studying these ef-

¹For example, in June 2025, unrest in downtown Los Angeles escalated into episodes of vandalism, looting, and arson. Businesses were burglarized, Waymo vehicles were set on fire, police cruisers were damaged by thrown rocks, and electric scooters were destroyed. Although the physical damage was concentrated within a limited area spanning only a few city blocks, the events attracted global attention following President Trump's deployment of the National Guard to the city's Civic Center. Grace Toohey, Rebecca Ellis, Matthew Ormseth, Hannah Fry and Michael Wilner, Downtown L.A. hit by widespread vandalism, damage as city struggles to calm unrest, June 2025, LA times, <https://www.latimes.com/california/story/2025-06-09/la-me-downtown-la-immigration-violence>

fects. First, they are timely, rich in narrative content, and sufficiently flexible to give managers substantial discretion over topic selection and framing (Frankel, Johnson, and Skinner, 1999; Matsumoto, Pronk, and Roelofsen, 2011). As a result, they allow observation of disclosure choices along multiple margins, including thematic composition, information quantity, and tone (Matsumoto et al., 2011; Fu, Wu, and Zhang, 2021). Second, conference calls are highly visible to investors and analysts, and their public-record nature can expose managers to subsequent scrutiny. Third, conference calls have become an important venue for discussing firms’ exposure to salient public issues (Balakrishnan, Copat, De La Parra, and Ramesh, 2023). These features make conference calls a natural setting in which to examine how nearby public activism shapes voluntary disclosure.

To test these arguments, I merge more than 170,000 public activism events from the Crowd Counting Consortium with Refinitiv earnings call transcripts from 2017 to 2023. I geocode protest events and link them to firms headquartered in the same ZIP code, consistent with conference-call narratives being shaped at headquarters, where nearby activism is most likely to affect the scrutiny surrounding managerial speech. Using Latent Dirichlet Allocation (LDA), I measure the thematic composition of calls across prepared remarks and QA segment (Huang, Lehav, Zang, and Zheng, 2018; Hassan, Hollander, van Lent, and Tahoun, 2019).

The evidence points to a scrutiny-driven disclosure response: firms exposed to nearby public activism provide less informative disclosure, use less negative language, and reallocate discussion away from attention sensitive topics toward safer strategic narratives.

Cross-sectional analyses further sharpen the interpretation. ESG-oriented activism is associated with a stronger shift away from financially sensitive topics. In contrast, finance- and economy-oriented activism is associated with relatively greater emphasis on performance-related topics and less discussion of macro-related topics. Taken together, these patterns suggest that managers anticipate the *ex post* scrutiny costs associated with different forms of nearby public activism and adjust the composition of voluntary disclosure accordingly *ex ante*.

To address identification concerns, I employ rainfall shocks, which exogenously reduce protest turnout (Madestam et al., 2013), as an instrumental variable for public activism participation. The IV results are broadly consistent with the OLS estimates, reinforcing the causal interpretation of the effect of public activism on firms’ voluntary disclosure.

I also examine whether these disclosure adjustments matter to investors. Market-reaction evidence suggests that firms exposed to PA, especially ESG-oriented activism, experience a more favorable three-day return around the call. I interpret this finding cautiously: it is more consistent with investors valuing context-appropriate and strategically adapted communication under heightened scrutiny than with any broad claim that less informative calls are inherently better.

This study contributes to three literatures. First, the paper contributes to research on public activism by showing that its consequences extend beyond firms’ real actions and market outcomes to managerial disclosure choices (McDonnell and King, 2013; Zhang et al., 2023). Second, this paper contributes to the voluntary disclosure literature by identifying PA as a novel non-market force that shapes disclosure incentives. Existing work emphasizes the role of investors, analysts, and other capital-market participants in driving financial and non-financial disclosure demand (Healy and Palepu, 2001; Friedman and Ormazabal, 2024; Cohen, Kadach, and Ormazabal, 2023; Abraham, Olbert, and Vasvari, 2024). I show that local communities, employees, customers, and advocacy groups can also reshape the scope, emphasis, and tone of corporate communication even though they do not supply capital or hold controlling rights directly. Third, the paper contributes to the literature on textual disclosure in earnings conference calls. Prior studies typically examine exposure to specific risk domains, such as political, climate, or racial risk (Hassan et al., 2019; Sautner, Van Lent, Vilkov, and Zhang, 2023; Balakrishnan et al., 2023). In contrast, I show that managers anticipate the *ex post* costs of public disclosure and adjust conference-call narratives *ex ante* in response to heightened public scrutiny. In particular, PA leads managers to reallocate discussion across multiple themes, with the effects concentrated in prepared remarks rather

than in the analyst Q&A.

The remainder of the paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 develops the hypotheses. Section 3 describes the data and methodology. Section 4 outlines the empirical design and presents the main results for general PA and overall call structure. Section 5 reports heterogeneity by PA type. Section 6 provides additional analyses. Section 7 presents robustness checks. Section 8 concludes.

2 Hypothesis Development

This paper examines whether public activism affects managerial disclosure in earnings conference calls. I argue that public activism can affect conference-call disclosure through two related channels: an economic-shock channel and an information/scrutiny channel.

First, public activism can affect firms' current and expected fundamentals. As a salient local shock, PA may disrupt operations, restrict access to facilities, increase security or repair costs, and create uncertainty about near-term revenues and cash flows (see Appendix C for earnings-call excerpts). It may also trigger boycotts, heighten local uncertainty, and create friction for future operations. When these effects are economically meaningful, investors are likely to demand more timely clarification about firm performance and prospects. Managers may therefore respond by providing additional context in public communications. Consistent with prior disclosure research, increases in information demand can induce firms to expand both voluntary disclosure and, where relevant, related mandatory disclosure to reduce information asymmetry and manage litigation risk ([Verrecchia, 1983](#); [Healy and Palepu, 2001](#); [Skinner, 1994](#)).

Second, PA can operate as an information and scrutiny shock. By making public concerns more visible, PA can intensify legitimacy assessments, increase reputational exposure, and redirect managerial attention toward stakeholder-facing issues([Suchman, 1995](#); [Deephouse and Suchman, 2008](#)). In this sense, nearby activism can make the concerns of local communities more salient to managers and potentially to other local audiences, including

investors and analysts (Zhang et al., 2023; Malloy, 2005; Seasholes and Zhu, 2010; Coval and Moskowitz, 1999). When such concerns become more salient, managers may anticipate greater scrutiny of conference-call statements by market participants and a greater likelihood that public remarks will later be evaluated, challenged, or reinterpreted outside the usual investor-analyst setting²

These two channels have distinct implications for disclosure. The economic-shock channel can increase investor demand for information by changing expected firm cash flows. The information/scrutiny channel can increase the expected cost of certain public statements by making them more exposed to *ex post* stakeholder challenge, reputational use, or reinterpretation. This logic fits naturally within the voluntary disclosure literature, which models disclosure as a tradeoff between benefits, such as reducing information asymmetry, and costs, such as litigation, proprietary, and other disclosure-related frictions (Verrecchia, 1983; Dye, 1985; Healy and Palepu, 2001; Leuz and Wysocki, 2016). The joint implication is not necessarily that firms disclose uniformly more or less, but that managers may adjust the composition of disclosure across thematic content and information quantity.

Against this background, I predict that public activism leads managers to adjust conference-call disclosure along two margins: thematic composition and information quantity. Because the scrutiny mechanism should matter most where managerial discretion is highest, the effects should be stronger in prepared remarks than in the analyst Q&A. In addition, if PA affects disclosure by increasing salience and scrutiny, the effects should be stronger when nearby activism is more intense.

2.1 Public Activism and Conference-Call Thematic Composition

If PA increases both local operating uncertainty and stakeholder scrutiny, managers have incentives to address the issues most relevant to investors while limiting unnecessary

²For instance, Papa John’s CEO steps down following the controversial remarks in the earnings call on NFL player’s protest. Scott Neuman, 2017, December, Papa John’s CEO Steps Down Following Controversial Remarks On NFL, <https://www.npr.org/sections/thetwo-way/2017/12/22/572779230/papa-johns-ceo-steps-down-following-controversial-remarks-on-nfl>. see Appendix C for detail comments.

exposure to statements that are more vulnerable to *ex post* stakeholder challenge or reputational reinterpretation. As a result, PA should affect not only whether managers speak more or less, but also what they choose to talk about. In particular, managers may reallocate discussion away from topics that are more sensitive or potentially challenge-prone and toward topics that explain current conditions, reassure investors, or emphasize broader strategic positioning. This prediction is consistent with the idea that managers use voluntary disclosure strategically when the expected benefits and costs of different forms of communication change.

H1. Public activism in the vicinity of a firm’s headquarters is associated with a reallocation of conference-call discussion across topics.

2.2 Public Activism and Information Quantity

PA can affect the amount of information managers provide for two opposing reasons. On the one hand, if activism changes expected cash flows or increases uncertainty, managers may have stronger incentives to explain firm performance, current conditions, and the firm’s outlook (Healy and Palepu, 2001). On the other hand, if activism also heightens stakeholder scrutiny, managers may avoid extensive discussion that could place sensitive interpretations or commitments on the public record (Dye, 1985; Healy and Palepu, 2001). The net effect on disclosure quantity is therefore ambiguous *ex ante* and must be resolved empirically.

H2. Public activism in the vicinity of a firm’s headquarters is associated with changes in the quantity of information disclosed in the firm’s conference calls.

2.3 Prepared Remarks versus Q&A

The effects of nearby activism should be stronger in prepared remarks than in the analyst Q&A. In prepared remarks, managers choose both the topics to address and the manner in which those topics are framed, making this portion of the call the most discretionary component of the disclosure. By contrast, the Q&A is shaped in part by analyst questioning and

immediate follow-up, which constrains managers' control over topic initiation and sequencing (Frankel et al., 1999; Matsumoto et al., 2011). If PA affects disclosure primarily by changing managers' incentives to proactively manage narrative exposure, those effects should appear more strongly in the segment where managers exercise the greatest discretion.

H3. The effects of nearby public activism on conference-call disclosure are stronger in the prepared remarks than in the Q&A portion of the call.

2.4 Intensity of Public Activism

If PA matters because it changes both the severity of the local shock and the salience of stakeholder concerns, its effects should be stronger when activism is more intense (Madestam et al., 2013; Zhang et al., 2023). Larger PA activity is more likely to attract attention, disrupt ordinary activity, and signal persistent stakeholder concern. More intense activism should therefore increase both the information value of speaking to the issue and the expected scrutiny associated with managerial speech.

H4. The association between nearby public activism and conference-call disclosure is stronger when PA participation is higher.

2.5 Heterogeneity by PA Type

The direction and form of the disclosure response may also vary with the type of PA. Different forms of public activism make different stakeholder concerns salient and may imply different economic consequences for the firm. For example, activism centered on social or environmental concerns may heighten attention to reputation, workforce relations, and community expectations, whereas activism related to economic and financial conditions may bear more directly on demand, costs, and operating performance. Accordingly, managers' disclosure responses may differ systematically across activism domains.

This heterogeneity is also informative about the underlying mechanism. If public activism affected conference-call disclosure only through a general economic-shock channel,

differences in disclosure responses across activism types should be limited once the severity of the shock is held constant. In contrast, systematic variation across activism domains would be more consistent with an information and stakeholder-scrutiny channel, under which activism changes not only the firm’s economic environment but also the specific concerns managers anticipate from salient non-investor audiences.

H5. The association between nearby public activism and conference-call disclosure varies with the type of public activism.

A reasonable counterargument is that public activism may have little effect on conference-call disclosure. Many protests are localized, short-lived, and not clearly material to firm value. For geographically diversified firms, such events may be too limited to warrant discussion on a public earnings call. Moreover, when PA is not directed at the firm, managers may prefer silence or boilerplate, especially if commentary could create a discoverable record, invite backlash, or later be challenged as inaccurate. Finally, even when PA contributes to broader political or institutional change, the mapping from protest activity to near-term cash flows may be too diffuse or delayed to affect current-quarter conference calls. These alternative views make the empirical tests important. The analysis therefore examines not only whether public activism is associated with disclosure changes, but also whether those changes are concentrated in the discretionary portion of the call and whether they vary systematically with activism salience and type.

3 Measurement and Data

3.1 Methodology

This study examines how public activism shapes firms’ voluntary disclosure in earnings conference calls. I integrate protest-event data, firm-level financial information, and conference-call transcripts, and I apply text-analysis methods to quantify changes in disclosure content, quantity, and tone. This design allows me to assess both the overall influence

of local public activism on disclosure and the extent to which the response differs between prepared remarks and analyst-driven Q&A.

3.1.1 Measurement of Conference-Call Thematic Content (LDA)

To quantify the thematic content of conference-call transcripts, I use Latent Dirichlet Allocation (LDA), a Bayesian computational linguistic model that identifies latent topics within a corpus by modeling word co-occurrence patterns (Blei, Ng, and Jordan, 2003). LDA is particularly well suited to conference calls because it allows the researcher to measure thematic content across a large set of transcripts over time without imposing strong priors on which themes should emerge.

The model estimates the proportion of each transcript devoted to different topics, allowing me to quantify and compare the relative emphasis on ESG-related, financial, strategic, and other themes across firms and over time. This flexibility is useful in the present setting because conference calls frequently combine discussions of financial results, operations, guidance, and broader strategy within the same transcript.

While LDA is widely used in accounting, finance, and economics research (Huang et al., 2018; Dyer, Lang, and Stice-Lawrence, 2017; Brown, Crowley, and Elliott, 2020), it is not without limitations (Miller, 2017). The approach requires several researcher decisions, such as defining the corpus, setting the number of topics, and labeling topics after estimation. To mitigate these concerns, I select the number of topics based on the coherence score (0.37) (Figure 2), manually validate the topic labels, and conduct robustness checks using alternative topic specifications and stop-word dictionaries.

[Figure 2 about here.]

I identify 75 latent topics and manually aggregate them into broader economic dimensions, such as strategy, corporate culture, and finance. For each transcript, I calculate the proportional weight of words associated with each topic; these topic proportions serve as dependent variables in the subsequent regression analyses.

3.1.2 Measurement of Public Activism

Based on each event’s stated claims and objectives in the source descriptions, including issue tags, narratives, and slogans, I hand-code PA events into six mutually exclusive categories: Environmental, Social, Governance, Finance (Economic), Politics, and Other. Environmental events include claims about climate, pollution, land and water protection, and resource use. Social covers civil rights, racial justice, immigration, public health, and community safety. Governance captures corporate accountability, anti-corruption, transparency, and regulatory integrity. Finance (Economic) includes banking, taxation, and macroeconomic grievances. Politics covers themes related to the presidency and public policy. Other is reserved for the remaining events. Appendix D provides the detailed coding rules, keyword examples, and additional illustrations for each category.

To measure PA exposure, I construct a binary variable, *PA_binary*, which equals one if at least one PA event occurs in the same district as the firm’s headquarters during a given quarter, and zero otherwise. To capture activism intensity, I aggregate the total number of participants for each ZIP code-quarter. Based on these measures, I construct: *Participation*, representing the logarithm of the total number of participants across all events.

3.2 Data

3.2.1 Public Activism

PA data come from the Crowd Counting Consortium (CCC), an academic initiative that systematically documents U.S. protest events since 2017. The CCC aggregates local and national news reports, verified social media posts, public submissions, and, when available, official records under a transparent coding protocol with researcher verification. Event-level fields include date, location (city, county, state, and latitude-longitude), issue and claim tags, organizational sponsorship, estimated participant counts (often with low and high bounds), counter-protest indicators, selected outcomes (e.g., arrests, injuries, and property

damage), and source citations. I use these microdata to construct ZIP-quarter measures of PA incidence and intensity, including log participants and total event counts, and then link them to firm headquarters by ZIP code. The initial dataset includes 171,532 events recorded between 2017 and 2023, covering 8,216 unique postal code areas across 2,281 counties in 50 U.S. states and 6 territories. Appendix B reports descriptive evidence on the demographics of PA.

3.2.2 Firm Characteristics

To link PA events to firm-level observations, I geocode each protest using the `Geopy` package, which converts latitude and longitude coordinates into postal codes. These geocoded events are then merged with firm-level financial data from Compustat, institutional ownership data from WRDS 13F, and analyst coverage from I/B/E/S.

3.2.3 Conference-Call Transcripts

Conference-call transcripts for the period 2017–2023 are sourced from Refinitiv. To ensure adequate textual content for topic modeling, I exclude transcripts containing fewer than 100 words. Table 1 outlines the sample construction process.

[Table 1 about here.]

The initial sample consists of 46,379 firm-quarter observations with conference-call transcripts from 2,760 unique firms between 2017 and 2023, for which non-missing lagged financial data are available. After excluding 76 singleton firm-quarters, each from a different firm, that cannot be used in fixed-effects regressions, the final sample comprises 46,303 firm-quarter observations from 2,684 unique firms. Within the final sample, 6,341 firm-quarter observations, corresponding to 291 firms, are associated with at least one PA event in the same district, defined by ZIP code, and quarter as the firm’s headquarters. The remaining 39,962 firm-quarter observations, corresponding to 2,393 firms, are from firms without any PA events in the same period. See Appendix A for variable definitions.

3.2.4 Summary Statistics

Table 2 reports summary statistics for the variables used in the analysis, covering 46,303 firm-quarter observations from 2017 to 2023 and the corresponding U.S. conference-call transcripts.

[Table 2 about here.]

[Table 3 about here.]

[Table 4 about here.]

Panel A reports summary statistics for PA exposure and conference-call content. PA exposure is present but not pervasive: *PA_binary* equals one for 14% of ZIP-quarter observations, with mean log participants of 0.60, respectively. By type, ESG activism is the most common, followed by finance/economic and political activism. Conference calls also exhibit meaningful variation in content and tone. The mean log of content words is 7.48, and the mean log of negative words is 3.45 overall, versus 2.58 in prepared remarks and 2.74 in Q&A. Topic shares are generally small, with prepared remarks weighted more toward opening, financial, and strategy-related topics, and Q&A weighted more toward strategy, guidance, costs, and negative-news topics. Appendix C reports the full topic table.

Panel B compares firms with and without PA exposure. Exposed firms are similar to non-exposed firms in observable characteristics, with only modest differences in leverage and PPE intensity. Overall, the differences are economically small, suggesting limited evidence that PA exposure is concentrated among firms with systematically different characteristics.

Panel C compares firms with and without conference calls. Firms that hold calls are larger, followed by more analysts, held more heavily by institutions, and somewhat more profitable than firms without calls. Relative to Robinson, Skinner, and Wang (2025), firms in my sample are smaller and less profitable on average, likely reflecting differences in sample period and coverage.

3.3 Empirical Framework

3.3.1 Baseline Model Specification

To assess the impact of public activism on disclosure behavior, I estimate reduced-form models for the main outcome variables, including topic distribution, raw and content word counts, and sentiment, using firm and year fixed effects. I describe the specific empirical specifications in the results sections that follow.

3.3.2 Instrumental Variable Approach

To address potential endogeneity concerns, such as omitted variable bias or reverse causality arising from macroeconomic or local conditions that could jointly affect PA and firm performance, I employ an instrumental variable (IV) strategy using rainfall as an instrument for public activism participation, following [Madestam et al. \(2013\)](#). The instrument exploits exogenous variation in weather conditions that affect the feasibility of outdoor protests but are unlikely to directly influence firms' disclosure behavior other than through their effect on PA intensity.

Daily precipitation data for 2017 to 2023 are obtained from the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration. I classify days with precipitation exceeding 2.54 millimeters (0.1 inch) as rainy and compute the number of rainy days per quarter at the county level, using FIPS codes, to construct the instrument. The validity of this instrument rests on two conditions: relevance and exogeneity. First, prior research shows that inclement weather significantly reduces protest participation by discouraging outdoor gatherings ([Madestam et al., 2013](#)). Second, rainfall is plausibly unrelated to unobservable factors that simultaneously drive both protest activity and firms' disclosure decisions, except through its impact on public activism.

Using this instrument, I implement a two-stage least squares (2SLS) framework to estimate the causal effect of public activism participation on the thematic content of conference

calls. This approach mitigates concerns that the observed association between PA events and disclosure is driven by omitted local economic conditions or reverse causality.

4 Main Results

This section presents the main evidence on whether local public activism changes conference-call disclosure. I test this question in three steps. First, I examine whether PA affects conference-call disclosure along two margins: thematic allocation and information quantity. Second, I ask whether these effects are concentrated in the presentation part of the call, where managerial discretion is greatest. Third, I examine whether the effects intensify when PA is more salient. I then use a rainfall-based instrumental-variables design to assess whether the documented relations admit a causal interpretation.

4.1 Public Activism and Thematic Composition

To assess the impact of public activism on thematic Composition, I estimate the following fixed-effects specification:

$$Topic_distribution_{it}^{(k)} = \alpha + \beta_1 PA_binary_{it} + \gamma X_{i,t-1} + \delta_i + \delta_t + \varepsilon_{it}, \quad (1)$$

where $Topic_distribution_{it}^{(k)}$ represents the proportion of words in the conference call of firm i at time t associated with topic k generated by the LDA procedure, such as corporate culture, finance, or strategy. PA_binary_{it} equals one if at least one public activism event occurs in the same district, defined by ZIP code, as firm i 's headquarters in quarter t , and zero otherwise. The control vector $X_{i,t-1}$ includes the lagged natural logarithm of total content words, $\ln(Content_words_{i,t-1})$, and lagged firm characteristics, including firm size, leverage, market-to-book, return on assets, and PPE, along with institutional ownership and analyst following. Firm and year fixed effects are denoted by δ_i and δ_t , respectively, and standard errors are clustered by firm. This specification follows prior conference-call

studies that document substantial cross-sectional heterogeneity in firm-level risk exposure and disclosure behavior (Hassan et al., 2019; Sautner et al., 2023).

Table 3 reports the relation between public activism and conference-call thematic allocation.

[Table 5 about here.]

[Table 6 about here.]

Table 3 Panel A shows that PA is associated with a systematic reallocation of discussion across topics. The broad pattern is not one of greater emphasis on immediate downside disclosure. Instead, managers appear to shift discussion toward product-market topics (0.0005, $p < 0.10$), strategy (0.0008, $p < 0.05$), and other relatively safer narratives, including transcript boilerplate (0.0020, $p < 0.01$) and positive guidance (0.0013, $p < 0.10$), while reducing attention to more financially sensitive topics, such as finance–capital allocation (−0.0008, $p < 0.10$) and negative guidance (−0.0028, $p < 0.01$).

The segment-level results in Table 3, Panel B strengthen this interpretation. In prepared remarks, where managers have the greatest discretion, PA is associated with more product-market and boilerplate discussion and less emphasis on financing topics such as buybacks and dividends. In Q&A segment, PA is associated with more positive guidance and less litigation-related negative guidance. Taken together, the evidence suggests that managers are not merely reacting to analyst questions; rather, they are proactively reshaping the narrative content of the call.

This pattern is consistent with managers selectively reallocating disclosure across subjects rather than simply expanding disclosure overall. When public activism heightens scrutiny and increases the expected cost of speaking, managers appear to shift away from topics that attract substantial investor attention and reaction, such as payout-related information and managerial guidance, and toward narratives that are more supportive of valuation while carrying lower downside risk.

Caveats. Although the estimated topic-share effects are modest in absolute terms, that is expected given the measurement design. Each transcript is distributed across 75 topics, so any one topic represents only a small portion of the overall discussion. The economically important point is therefore the consistent directional pattern across related topics rather than the magnitude of any single coefficient.

4.2 Public Activism and Information Quantity

I next examine whether public activism affects the amount of information managers provide in conference calls. To do so, I estimate the following models:

$$\ln(\text{Content_words}_{it}) = \alpha + \beta_1 \text{PA_binary}_{it} + \gamma X_{i,t-1} + \delta_i + \delta_t + \varepsilon_{it}, \quad (2)$$

$$N_Questions_{it} = \alpha + \beta_1 \text{PA_binary}_{it} + \gamma X_{i,t-1} + \delta_i + \delta_t + \varepsilon_{it}, \quad (3)$$

where $\ln(\text{Content_words}_{it})$ is the natural logarithm of informative words in the transcript, constructed using an LDA-based dictionary that removes non-informative function words such as “you,” “I,” and “they.” In alternative specifications, I also use the natural logarithm of raw transcript words. PA_binary_{it} equals one if at least one public activism event occurs in the same district as the firm’s headquarters in quarter t , and zero otherwise. $N_Questions_{it}$ is the number of analyst questions asked during the call. The control vector $X_{i,t-1}$ includes lagged institutional holdings, analyst coverage, market-to-book, firm size, leverage, PPE, and return on assets. Firm and year fixed effects are included, and standard errors are clustered by firm.

As reported in Table 4, PA exposure is associated with shorter and less informative conference calls.

[Table 7 about here.]

The coefficient on *PA_binary* is negative and statistically significant across specifications, approximately -0.0134 ($p < 0.05$) in Column (1) and -0.0145 ($p < 0.05$) in Column (2), indicating reduced content words in the full call and, more specifically, in the presentation segment. Economically, this corresponds to roughly a 1.4% reduction in content length. Column (3) further shows that analysts ask fewer questions on average, with the number of questions declining by about 2.6%. By contrast, the coefficient on raw transcript length (-0.0051) is not statistically significant, suggesting that managers do not necessarily speak fewer total words; rather, the informational content of the call declines.

4.3 The Role of PA Intensity

The next set of tests examines whether the response is stronger when local activism is more salient. To do so, I estimate the following specifications using high-intensity activism measures:

$$Topic_distribution_{it}^{(k)} = \alpha + \beta_1 Participation_high_{it} + \gamma X_{i,t-1} + \delta_i + \delta_t + \varepsilon_{it}, \quad (4a)$$

$$\ln(Content_words_{it}) = \alpha + \beta_1 Participation_high_{it} + \gamma X_{i,t-1} + \delta_i + \delta_t + \varepsilon_{it}, \quad (4b)$$

$$\ln(Negative_words_{it}) = \alpha + \beta_1 Participation_high_{it} + \gamma X_{i,t-1} + \delta_i + \delta_t + \varepsilon_{it}. \quad (4c)$$

where *Participation_high* equals one if ZIP-quarter protest participation exceeds the sample median. The control vector $X_{i,t-1}$ includes lagged institutional holdings, analyst coverage, market-to-book, firm size, leverage, PPE, and return on assets. Firm and year fixed effects are included, and standard errors are clustered by firm.

Table 5 shows that higher-intensity activism is associated with further reallocation of conference-call discussion across topics. The clearest pattern is a shift toward financial and strategic topics, particularly negative guidance, and away from social and positive-guidance topics. This pattern is consistent with the view that larger protest participation raises the

expected scrutiny cost of public statements. In response, managers appear to communicate more cautiously, placing greater emphasis on financially topics while reducing attention to non-financial discussion that may attract greater stakeholder scrutiny and adopting more conservative forward-looking guidance.

[Table 8 about here.]

Table 6 reinforces that conclusion. High participation drives the decline in disclosure informativeness. Larger protests therefore appear to change disclosure incentives more strongly, suggesting greater caution when scrutiny is especially salient.

[Table 9 about here.]

4.4 Instrumental Variable Evidence

To strengthen the causal interpretation, I instrument protest participation with the number of rainy days in the quarter, following Madestam et al. (2013). The logic is that adverse weather reduces protest turnout by raising the cost of participation while being plausibly unrelated to firms' conference-call disclosure except through activism intensity.

Table 7 presents the instrumental-variables analysis, in which rainfall serves as an instrument for public activism participation.

[Table 10 about here.]

[Table 11 about here.]

[Table 12 about here.]

Panel A reports the first-stage results linking total rainy days in a quarter to PA participation measures. Rainfall is negatively and significantly associated with the log number of participants in all activism events. The coefficient on rainfall is -0.0249 ($p < 0.01$), indicating that greater rainfall suppresses public activism turnout.

Panel B presents the second-stage 2SLS estimates of the effect of PA participation on the information content of conference calls. Using county-level rainfall as an instrument for PA participation, the second stage shows that higher participation significantly reduces information content. The coefficient on $\ln(\textit{Participants})$ is -0.18 ($p < 0.10$), implying that an increase in participation lowers call content, measured as $\ln(\textit{Content_words})$. The specification includes firm and time fixed effects and the standard set of controls. These IV results suggest that exogenous increases in local PA participation causally reduce the amount of information firms provide on conference calls.

Panel C reports the 2SLS estimates of how PA participation reallocates disclosure across topics, again instrumenting $\ln(\textit{Participants})$ with county-level rainfall. Higher participation significantly reduces discussion of both Social–Corporate Culture and Strategy–Growth. The coefficients on $\ln(\textit{Participants})$ are -0.0209 ($p < 0.05$) and -0.0206 ($p < 0.10$), respectively, suggesting that firms become more cautious under heightened stakeholder uncertainty.

The IV topic results also align with the baseline evidence: higher participation lowers discussion of selected growth- and culture-related topics. These estimates are necessarily narrower than the full reduced-form results, but they point in the same direction. Overall, the IV evidence reinforces rather than overturns the main interpretation. Exogenous increases in protest participation appear to make disclosure more cautious and less expansive, reducing the concern that the baseline relations are driven entirely by omitted local conditions or reverse causality.

5 Heterogeneity Test

This section examines whether the disclosure response varies with the type of activism. The key idea is that activism type changes both the kind of stakeholder pressure the firm faces and the expected cost of speaking about different subjects. Accordingly, the relevant comparison is not whether all protest types produce identical coefficients, but whether they produce systematically different patterns.

To assess the association between public activism type and topic variation, I estimate the following fixed-effects specification:

$$Topic_distribution_{it}^{(k)} = \alpha + \beta_1 PA_Type_{it} + \gamma X_{i,t-1} + \delta_i + \delta_t + \varepsilon_{it}, \quad (5)$$

where $Topic_distribution_{it}^{(k)}$ represents the proportion of words in the conference call of firm i at time t associated with topic k generated by the LDA procedure. PA_Type_{it} equal one if at least one ESG-, finance-, or politics-related public activism event, respectively, occurs in the same district, defined by ZIP code, as the firm’s headquarters in quarter t , and zero otherwise. The control vector $X_{i,t-1}$ includes the lagged natural logarithm of total content words, $\ln(Content_words_{i,t-1})$, and lagged firm characteristics, including firm size, leverage, market-to-book, return on assets, PPE, institutional ownership, and analyst following. Firm and year fixed effects are included, and standard errors are clustered by firm.

5.1 Public Activism Type and Thematic Allocation

ESG Activism and Topic Variation. Table 8 shows that ESG-oriented activism produces the clearest and most distinctive topical response.

[Table 13 about here.]

Exposure to ESG activism is associated with less discussion of M&A, capital allocation, growth-oriented strategy, and litigation-related negative guidance, together with relatively greater emphasis on current strategy and market positioning. The pattern is strongest in prepared remarks and is consistent with ESG activism increasing the cost of discussing financially sensitive or expansionary topics under heightened legitimacy scrutiny.

This is the paper’s most compelling heterogeneity result. ESG activism does not simply make calls more negative or more expansive. Instead, it shifts discussion away from topics that are easier to challenge *ex post* and toward narratives that are more compatible with stakeholder-facing reputation management.

Financial Activism and Topic Variation. Table 9 shows a different pattern for finance- and economy-oriented activism.

[Table 14 about here.]

Here the response shifts discussion toward a broader set of performance-relevant and strategy-related topics, such as growth, product-market issues, and capital allocation, while reducing attention to broader macroeconomic and pandemic-related discussion. This pattern fits the idea that finance-oriented activism changes the demand for business-fundamental discussion rather than primarily raising legitimacy-sensitive disclosure costs.

In other words, finance-oriented activism appears to elicit a more business-facing response, whereas ESG activism elicits a more scrutiny-sensitive one. That distinction is important because it suggests that managers respond to the content of stakeholder pressure, not merely to the existence of nearby protest activity.

Political Activism and Topic Variation. Table 10 indicates that political activism produces a pattern that is directionally closer to finance-oriented activism than to ESG activism, but generally weaker and less central to the paper’s contribution. Firms shift discussion away from macro-environment themes and toward some growth, M&A, and positive-guidance language, but the interpretation is less sharp than for ESG activism.

[Table 15 about here.]

Taken together, the heterogeneity results suggest that public activism affects firm disclosure not simply through general economic disruption. Instead, the disclosure response depends on the nature of the scrutiny and information demand created by the protest environment.

5.2 Public Activism Type and Conference-Call Information Quantity

I next examine whether the effect of public activism on conference-call length varies by protest type. To do so, I estimate the following specification:

$$\ln(\text{Content_words}_{it}) = \alpha + \beta_1 \text{ESG_} \text{ or } \beta_1 \text{FIN_} \text{ or } \beta_1 \text{POLI_Activism}_{it} + \gamma X_{i,t-1} + \delta_i + \delta_t + \varepsilon_{it}, \quad (6)$$

where $\ln(\text{Content_words}_{it})$ is the natural logarithm of informative words in the transcript, constructed using an LDA-based dictionary that removes non-informative function words. *ESG_Activism_Binary*, *FIN_Activism_Binary*, and *POLI_Activism_Binary* are defined as above. The control vector $X_{i,t-1}$ includes lagged institutional holdings, analyst coverage, market-to-book, firm size, leverage, PPE, and return on assets. Firm and year fixed effects are included, and standard errors are clustered by firm.

Table 11 shows that *ESG_Activism_Binary* is negative and statistically significant (-0.0173, $p < 0.01$), implying that calls are about 1.7% shorter when ESG-oriented protests occur near the firm’s headquarters. By contrast, the coefficients on *FIN_Activism_Binary* and *POLI_Activism_Binary* are small and statistically indistinguishable from zero. This pattern is consistent with the idea that ESG activism raises the relative cost of expansive public discussion without necessarily increasing the demand for more detailed financial commentary.

[Table 16 about here.]

6 Additional Analyses

6.1 Public Activism and Conference-Call Sentiment

In addition to affecting what managers discuss and how much they say, public activism may also affect how managers frame their disclosures. Prior research shows that tone conveys information to market participants but also reflects managerial incentives in high-visibility communication settings (Huang, Teoh, and Zhang, 2014; Loughran and McDonald, 2016). When PA heightens scrutiny, managers may have stronger incentives to avoid language that could later be interpreted adversely, appear unnecessarily alarmist, or invite additional

challenge. Tone therefore provides a second margin through which managers can adapt to a more contested disclosure environment. This logic is consistent with evidence that tone in conference calls reflects managerial attributes and strategic communication incentives rather than merely contemporaneous fundamentals.

I test whether PA is associated with the sentiment of conference calls by estimating the natural logarithm of the count of sentiment words, based on the Loughran and McDonald dictionary, on PA exposure and PA type (Loughran and McDonald, 2011).

Table 12, Panel A shows that PA is negatively associated with negative tone across segments. The coefficient on *PA_Binary* is -0.0379 ($p < 0.01$) for the full call, -0.0390 ($p < 0.01$) in the presentation segment, and -0.0288 ($p < 0.05$) in the Q&A segment, implying reductions of roughly 3.8%, 3.9%, and 2.8% in negative word counts, respectively. Panel B presents the heterogeneous results. *FIN_Activism_Binary* loads negatively and significantly (-0.0295, $p < 0.05$), whereas *ESG_Activism_Binary* and *POLI_Activism_Binary* are small and statistically indistinguishable from zero.

[Table 17 about here.]

[Table 18 about here.]

Overall, the evidence indicates that PA exposure is associated with a generally less negative tone, consistent with managers softening their language when external activism heightens stakeholder scrutiny.

6.2 Market Returns

A final question is whether these disclosure adjustments matter for investors. If PA changes the salience of risk, stakeholder scrutiny, or future operating constraints, investors may react not only to the activism shock itself but also to how managers adapt their disclosure around the earnings call.

To assess market consequences, I implement a standard daily event-study design and estimate expected returns using the Fama–French three-factor model augmented with momentum (Fama and French, 1993; Carhart, 1997). I report both cumulative abnormal returns (CAR) and cumulative total returns (CRET) over the three-day earnings-call window and include firm and time fixed effects with standard errors clustered by firm.

Panel A of Table 13 reports the association between PA exposure and market reactions around conference calls. The coefficient on *PA_Binary* is positive across specifications. When the dependent variable is CAR (Columns (1) and (3)), the estimate is economically small and statistically indistinguishable from zero, suggesting no reliable difference in risk-adjusted abnormal performance in the short window. In contrast, when the dependent variable is CRET (Columns (2) and (4)), *PA_Binary* loads positively and significantly (0.0058 and 0.0062, both significant at the 5% level). These estimates imply that firms exposed to PA earn approximately 0.6% higher buy-and-hold returns around the call relative to non-exposed firms. The results suggest that activism exposure is associated with a modestly more favorable raw market reaction around conference calls, while the corresponding abnormal-return effect is not precisely estimated.

Panel B of Table 13 decomposes PA exposure by type and shows that the positive return pattern is concentrated in ESG-related activism. *ESG_Activism_Binary* is positive and significant for both CAR and CRET (CAR = 0.0053; CRET = 0.0094; significant at the 5% and 1% levels, respectively), consistent with ESG activism being associated with a more favorable short-window market response around conference calls. By contrast, the coefficients on *FIN_Activism_Binary* and *POLI_Activism_Binary* are small and statistically insignificant for both return measures, suggesting that the market reaction is not uniform across PA domains.

[Table 19 about here.]

[Table 20 about here.]

The market-reaction evidence suggests that investors do respond to these disclosure adjustments. The positive return association is concentrated in ESG activism, which is also the category most strongly associated with shorter, more selectively curated calls. This pattern is consistent with investors valuing context-appropriate and strategically adapted communication under activism-related uncertainty rather than simply rewarding shorter calls *per se*.

By contrast, the absence of comparable effects for finance-related and political activism is consistent with these events conveying information that is broader and more macro in nature—information that is likely impounded into prices prior to the conference call, so that little incremental reaction remains concentrated in the call window.

7 Robustness Test

7.1 Dropping Large Cities

As a robustness test, I re-estimate the baseline models after excluding observations from New York, a location that may exert disproportionate influence because of its unusually dense protest activity, media attention, and concentration of large firms. Specifically, I repeat the main analyses for thematic allocation, disclosure quantity, and tone after removing firm-quarter observations headquartered in New York.

The results remain substantively unchanged. Across specifications, the key coefficients preserve their signs, remain economically similar in magnitude, and continue to exhibit comparable levels of statistical significance. These findings suggest that the main results are not driven by region-specific effects or by a small number of observations from unusually prominent urban areas.

8 Conclusion

This paper examines how geographically proximate public activism shapes firms' voluntary disclosure in earnings conference calls. This paper examines how geographically proximate public activism shapes firms' voluntary disclosure in earnings conference calls. I document three main findings. First, public activism is associated with systematic reallocation of conference-call discussion across topics. On average, firms shift discussion away from topics that are more financially sensitive or more vulnerable to *ex post* stakeholder reaction and toward relatively safer strategic narratives. Second, public activism is associated with less informative disclosure, reflected in fewer content words and fewer analyst questions, even though raw transcript length changes little. Third, activism exposure is associated with less negative tone. These effects are concentrated in prepared remarks, where managerial discretion is greatest, and become stronger when activism participation is higher. Additional analyses further show that the disclosure response varies by activism type, with ESG-oriented activism producing the clearest shift away from financially sensitive and expansionary topics.

Several limitations should be noted. The headquarters-based design is well suited to the conference-call setting, but it may not capture all channels through which activism affects geographically diversified firms. In addition, the topic-modeling approach requires researcher judgment in selecting the number of topics and labeling the resulting themes. Although the results are robust to alternative specifications, text-based measures necessarily provide an imperfect representation of firms' underlying communication choices. Finally, although the instrumental-variables evidence strengthens causal inference, it is narrower than the full reduced-form analysis.

These limitations suggest several directions for future research. One avenue is to examine whether similar responses arise in other disclosure settings, such as earnings press releases, periodic filings, or investor presentations. Another is to study whether repeated exposure to activism changes firms' disclosure practices over longer horizons. More broadly, future work may help clarify how firms adapt disclosure when pressure comes not only from capital-

market participants, but also from salient nonmarket audiences.

Overall, the evidence suggests that public activism affects not only firms' operating environment, but also their disclosure environment. When public scrutiny intensifies, managers appear to communicate more selectively, adjusting both the quantity and the composition of conference-call disclosure.

References

- Abraham, Jefferson, Marcel Olbert, and Florin Vasvari, 2024, ESG Disclosures in the Private Equity Industry, *Journal of Accounting Research* 62, 1611–1660, eprint: <https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/pdf/10.1111/1475-679X.12570>.
- Acemoglu, Daron, and James A. Robinson, 2000, Why Did the West Extend the Franchise? Democracy, Inequality, and Growth in Historical Perspective, *The Quarterly Journal of Economics* 115, 1167–1199.
- Balakrishnan, Karthik, Rafael Copat, Daniela De La Parra, and K. Ramesh, 2023, Racial Diversity Exposure and Firm Responses Following the Murder of George Floyd, *Journal of Accounting Research* 61, 737–804.
- Barrett, Philip, Mariia Bondar, Sophia Chen, Mali Chivakul, and Deniz Igan, 2024, Pricing protest: the response of financial markets to social unrest, *Review of Finance* 28, 1419–1450.
- Blei, David M, Andrew Y Ng, and Michael I Jordan, 2003, Latent dirichlet allocation, *Journal of machine Learning research* 3, 993–1022.
- Brav, Alon, Wei Jiang, Frank Partnoy, and Randall Thomas, 2008, Hedge fund activism, corporate governance, and firm performance, *The Journal of Finance* 63, 1729–1775.
- Briscoe, Forrest, and Abhinav Gupta, 2016, Social Activism in and Around Organizations, *Academy of Management Annals* 10, 671–727.
- Brown, Nerissa C, Richard M Crowley, and W Brooke Elliott, 2020, What are you saying? using topic to detect financial misreporting, *Journal of Accounting Research* 58, 237–291.
- Carhart, Mark M, 1997, On persistence in mutual fund performance, *The Journal of finance* 52, 57–82.
- Cohen, Shira, Igor Kadach, and Gaizka Ormazabal, 2023, Institutional investors, climate disclosure, and carbon emissions, *Journal of Accounting and Economics* 76, 101640.
- Coval, Joshua D, and Tobias J Moskowitz, 1999, Home bias at home: Local equity preference in domestic portfolios, *The Journal of Finance* 54, 2045–2073.
- Deephouse, David L, and Mark Suchman, 2008, Legitimacy in organizational institutionalism, *The Sage handbook of organizational institutionalism* 49, 273–289.

- Dye, Ronald A., 1985, Disclosure of Nonproprietary Information, *Journal of Accounting Research* 23, 123–145.
- Dyer, Travis, Mark Lang, and Lorien Stice-Lawrence, 2017, The evolution of 10-k textual disclosure: Evidence from latent dirichlet allocation, *Journal of Accounting and Economics* 64, 221–245.
- Fama, Eugene F, and Kenneth R French, 1993, Common risk factors in the returns on stocks and bonds, *Journal of financial economics* 33, 3–56.
- Frankel, Richard, Marilyn Johnson, and Douglas J. Skinner, 1999, An Empirical Examination of Conference Calls as a Voluntary Disclosure Medium, *Journal of Accounting Research* 37, 133–150.
- Freeman, R. Edward, 2010, *Strategic Management: A Stakeholder Approach*, first edition (Cambridge University Press).
- Friedman, Henry L., and Gaizka Ormazabal, 2024, The Role of Information in Building a More Sustainable Economy: A Supply and Demand Perspective, *Journal of Accounting Research* 62, 1575–1609, eprint: <https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/pdf/10.1111/1475-679X.12581>.
- Fu, Xi, Xiaoxi Wu, and Zhifang Zhang, 2021, The Information Role of Earnings Conference Call Tone: Evidence from Stock Price Crash Risk, *Journal of Business Ethics* 173, 643–660.
- Gillan, Stuart L, and Laura T Starks, 2000, Corporate governance proposals and shareholder activism: The role of institutional investors, *Journal of financial Economics* 57, 275–305.
- Hassan, Tarek A., Stephan Hollander, Laurence van Lent, and Ahmed Tahoun, 2019, Firm-Level Political Risk: Measurement and Effects, *The Quarterly Journal of Economics* 134, 2135–2202.
- Healy, Paul M, and Krishna G Palepu, 2001, Information asymmetry, corporate disclosure, and the capital markets: A review of the empirical disclosure literature\$.
- Huang, Allen H., Reuven Lehavy, Amy Y. Zang, and Rong Zheng, 2018, Analyst Information Discovery and Interpretation Roles: A Topic Modeling Approach, *Management Science* 64, 2833–2855.
- Huang, Xuan, Siew Hong Teoh, and Yinglei Zhang, 2014, Tone Management, *The Accounting Review* 89, 1083–1113.

- Konwar, Ziko, Yingqi Wei, Geoffrey Wood, and Jeremy Eng-Tuck Cheah, 2024, The public as a definitive stakeholder of corporate environmental sustainability practices: A cross-national institutional approach, *Journal of Environmental Management* 370, 122666.
- Leuz, Christian, and Peter D. Wysocki, 2016, The Economics of Disclosure and Financial Reporting Regulation: Evidence and Suggestions for Future Research, *Journal of Accounting Research* 54, 525–622, eprint: <https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/pdf/10.1111/1475-679X.12115>.
- Loughran, Tim, and Bill McDonald, 2011, When is a liability not a liability? textual analysis, dictionaries, and 10-ks, *The Journal of Finance* 66, 35–65.
- Loughran, Tim, and Bill McDonald, 2016, Textual Analysis in Accounting and Finance: A Survey, *Journal of Accounting Research* 54, 1187–1230, eprint: <https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/pdf/10.1111/1475-679X.12123>.
- Madestam, Andreas, Daniel Shoag, Stan Veuger, and David Yanagizawa-Drott, 2013, Do Political Protests Matter? Evidence from the Tea Party Movement*, *The Quarterly Journal of Economics* 128, 1633–1685.
- Malloy, Christopher J, 2005, The geography of equity analysis, *The Journal of Finance* 60, 719–755.
- Matsumoto, Dawn, Maarten Pronk, and Erik Roelofsen, 2011, What Makes Conference Calls Useful? The Information Content of Managers’ Presentations and Analysts’ Discussion Sessions, *The Accounting Review* 86, 1383–1414.
- McDonnell, Mary-Hunter, and Brayden King, 2013, Keeping up Appearances: Reputational Threat and Impression Management after Social Movement Boycotts, *Administrative Science Quarterly* 58, 387–419.
- Miller, Gregory S, 2017, Discussion of “the evolution of 10-k textual disclosure: Evidence from latent dirichlet allocation”, *Journal of Accounting and Economics* 64, 246–252.
- Ormazábal, Gaizka, 2018, The role of stakeholders in corporate governance: A view from accounting research, *Foundations and Trends® in Accounting* 11, 193–290.
- Robinson, Scott A, A Nicole Skinner, and Jasmine Wang, 2025, Does litigation risk shape environmental disclosure decisions? evidence from peers’ environmental disclosure lawsuits, *The Accounting Review* 100, 445–475.

- Sautner, Zacharias, Laurence Van Lent, Grigory Vilkov, and Ruishen Zhang, 2023, Firm-Level Climate Change Exposure, *The Journal of Finance* 78, 1449–1498, eprint: <https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/pdf/10.1111/jofi.13219>.
- Seasholes, Mark S, and Ning Zhu, 2010, Individual investors and local bias, *The Journal of Finance* 65, 1987–2010.
- Shleifer, Andrei, and Robert W Vishny, 1986, Large shareholders and corporate control, *Journal of political economy* 94, 461–488.
- Skinner, Douglas J, 1994, Why firms voluntarily disclose bad news, *Journal of accounting research* 32, 38–60.
- Suchman, Mark C, 1995, Managing legitimacy: Strategic and institutional approaches, *Academy of management review* 20, 571–610.
- Verrecchia, Robert E., 1983, Discretionary disclosure, *Journal of Accounting and Economics* 5, 179–194.
- Zhang, Muhan, Forrest Briscoe, and Mark R. DesJardine, 2023, Corporate Boards with Street Smarts? How Diffuse Street Protests Indirectly Shape Corporate Governance, *Administrative Science Quarterly* 68, 1056–1093.

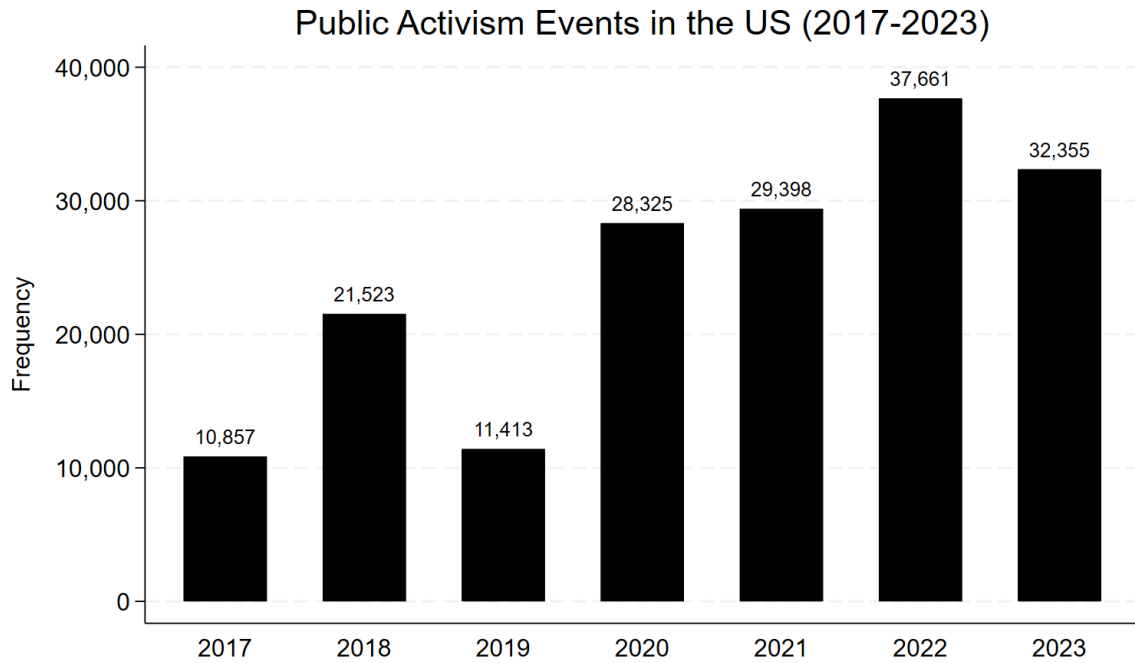


Figure 1: U.S. public activism events, 2017–2023

Note: This figure shows the number of protest events recorded by the Crowd Counting Consortium between 2017 and 2023.

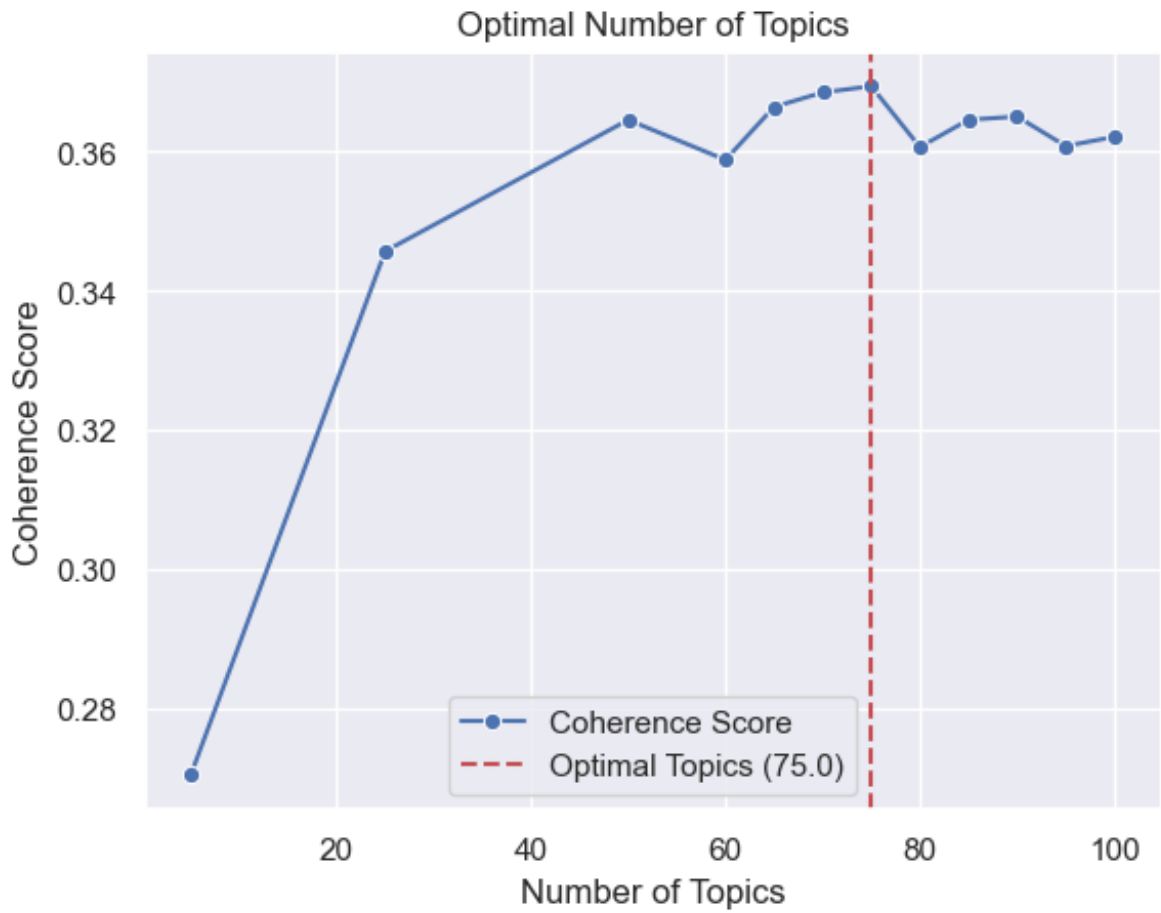


Figure 2: The optimal coherence score for topics

Note: This figure shows the number of optimal topics and cohenrence score generated by LDA.

Table 1: Sample Construction

Steps of the sample selection procedure	# Firm-Quarters	# Individual Firms
Firm-quarter observations with conference-call transcripts longer than 100 words and non-missing lagged financial data from 2017 to 2023	46,379	2,760
Less: Singleton observations	(76)	(76)
Final sample	46,303	2,684
Firm-quarters with at least one PA event	6,341	291
Firm-quarters with no PA events	39,962	2,393

Notes: This table describes the sample-construction procedure. The initial sample consists of firm-quarter observations with earnings conference-call transcripts from Refinitiv containing more than 100 words and with non-missing lagged financial data over 2017–2023. Singleton observations are excluded because they cannot be used in fixed-effects regressions. The final sample is then partitioned into firm-quarters with and without at least one public activism (PA) event occurring in the same district (by ZIP code) and quarter as the firm’s headquarters.

Table 2: Summary Statistics

Variables	N	Mean	Sd	Min	Max	25%	75%
<i>Panel A: PA Events and Topic Distribution</i>							
<i>PA Events</i>							
<i>PA_binary</i>	46,303	0.14	0.34	0.00	1.00	0.00	0.00
<i>Ln_PA_Count</i>	46,303	0.21	0.64	0.00	3.30	0.00	0.00
<i>Ln_Participants</i>	46,303	0.60	1.86	0.00	8.51	0.00	0.00
<i>ESG_Activism_Binary</i>	46,303	0.18	0.58	0.00	2.08	0.00	0.00
<i>FIN_Activism_Binary</i>	46,303	0.04	0.18	0.00	1.10	0.00	0.00
<i>POLI_Activism_Binary</i>	46,303	0.03	0.17	0.00	1.10	0.00	0.00
<i>Topic Distribution: Overall</i>							
<i>Ln_Content_words</i>	46,303	7.48	0.41	6.23	8.31	7.22	7.79
<i>Ln_Negative_Words</i>	46,303	3.45	0.60	0.00	3.90	3.09	3.87
<i>Ln_Negative_Words_PRE</i>	46,303	2.58	0.72	0.69	4.08	2.08	3.09
<i>Ln_Negative_Words_Q&A</i>	46,303	2.74	0.87	0.00	4.22	2.30	3.37
<i>topic_1_Introduction</i>	46,303	0.07	0.05	0.00	0.25	0.03	0.10
<i>topic_3_Social_Corporate_Culture</i>	46,303	0.01	0.03	0.00	0.12	0.00	0.02
<i>topic_13_Uncertainty</i>	46,303	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.02	0.00	0.00
<i>topic_16_Product_Market</i>	46,303	0.01	0.02	0.00	0.10	0.00	0.02
<i>topic_17_M&A</i>	46,303	0.02	0.03	0.00	0.15	0.00	0.02
<i>topic_22_Financial_Revenue</i>	46,303	0.05	0.06	0.00	0.26	0.00	0.07
<i>topic_24_Strategy_Guidance</i>	46,303	0.02	0.03	0.00	0.15	0.00	0.04
<i>topic_25_Politics_Legislation</i>	46,303	0.01	0.03	0.00	0.17	0.00	0.00
<i>topic_27_Negative_Guidance_Market</i>	46,303	0.01	0.04	0.00	0.19	0.00	0.00
<i>topic_28_Strategy_Market</i>	46,303	0.01	0.04	0.00	0.25	0.00	0.00
<i>topic_29_Strategy_Growth</i>	46,303	0.00	0.01	0.00	0.03	0.00	0.00
<i>topic_32_Guidance_Gross_Margin</i>	46,303	0.02	0.03	0.00	0.11	0.00	0.03
<i>topic_40_Financial_Cost</i>	46,303	0.05	0.06	0.00	0.24	0.00	0.07

Table 2: Summary Statistics (continued)

Variables	N	Mean	Sd	Min	Max	25%	75%
<i>Panel A: PA Events and Topic Distribution (continued)</i>							
<i>topic_43_Social_Labor</i>	46,303	0.01	0.02	0.00	0.10	0.00	0.00
<i>topic_46_Strategy_Growth</i>	46,303	0.07	0.07	0.00	0.28	0.00	0.11
<i>topic_48_Transcript_Boilerplate</i>	46,303	0.01	0.02	0.00	0.13	0.00	0.00
<i>topic_49_Transcript_Boilerplate</i>	46,303	0.02	0.03	0.00	0.10	0.00	0.04
<i>topic_50_Strategy_Marketing</i>	46,303	0.01	0.04	0.00	0.20	0.00	0.00
<i>topic_54_Macro_Environment</i>	46,303	0.01	0.03	0.00	0.17	0.00	0.00
<i>topic_55_Covid</i>	46,303	0.01	0.03	0.00	0.13	0.00	0.00
<i>topic_63_Partnerships</i>	46,303	0.01	0.03	0.00	0.13	0.00	0.02
<i>topic_66_Covid_Downturn_Recovery</i>	46,303	0.01	0.03	0.00	0.17	0.00	0.01
<i>topic_69_Positive_Guidance</i>	46,303	0.04	0.06	0.00	0.28	0.00	0.06
<i>topic_70_Financial_Capital_Allocation</i>	46,303	0.02	0.03	0.00	0.15	0.00	0.04
<i>topic_71_Negative_Guidance_Litigation</i>	46,303	0.05	0.06	0.00	0.34	0.02	0.07
<i>topic_72_Human_Resource</i>	46,303	0.01	0.02	0.00	0.10	0.00	0.02
<i>Panel B: Firm Characteristics by PA Exposure</i>							
<i>Firm-quarters with public activism events</i>							
<i>Analyst_follow</i>	6,341	2.87	2.63	0.00	6.56	0.00	5.41
<i>Ins_holding</i>	6,341	16.57	7.53	0.00	26.72	15.60	21.34
<i>Firm_Size</i>	6,341	6.76	2.67	-2.60	12.05	5.03	8.69
<i>Leverage</i>	6,341	0.23	0.22	0.00	1.00	0.04	0.38
<i>PPE</i>	6,341	0.21	0.27	0.00	0.91	0.01	0.31
<i>Market_to_book</i>	6,341	-0.03	1.46	-2.82	4.29	-1.02	0.91
<i>ROA</i>	6,341	-0.02	0.18	-2.67	0.13	-0.01	0.03
<i>Firm-quarters without public activism events</i>							
<i>Analyst_follow</i>	39,962	2.70	2.06	0.00	6.56	0.00	5.15
<i>Ins_holding</i>	39,962	16.17	7.84	0.00	26.72	15.11	21.23
<i>Firm_Size</i>	39,962	6.53	2.51	-2.60	12.05	4.87	8.22
<i>Leverage</i>	39,962	0.25	0.22	0.00	1.00	0.05	0.40
<i>PPE</i>	39,962	0.20	0.24	0.00	0.91	0.02	0.29
<i>Market_to_book</i>	39,962	0.22	1.33	-2.82	4.29	-0.51	1.04
<i>ROA</i>	39,962	-0.02	0.17	-2.67	0.13	-0.02	0.03

Table 2: Summary Statistics (continued)

Variables	N	Mean	Sd	Min	Max	25%	75%
<i>Panel C: Firm Characteristics by Conference-Call Availability</i>							
<i>Firm-quarters with conference calls</i>							
<i>Analyst_follow</i>	46,303	2.54	2.56	0.00	6.56	0.00	5.08
<i>Ins_holding</i>	46,303	15.96	8.04	0.00	26.72	14.81	21.24
<i>Firm_Size</i>	46,303	6.43	2.55	-2.60	12.05	4.75	8.16
<i>Leverage</i>	46,303	0.46	5.93	0.00	18.58.00	0.05	0.41
<i>PPE</i>	46,303	0.20	0.24	0.00	0.91	0.02	0.28
<i>Market_to_book</i>	46,303	-0.16	1.34	-3.25	3.60	-1.01	0.72
<i>ROA</i>	46,303	-0.03	0.19	-2.67	0.13	-0.02	0.03
<i>Firm-quarters without conference calls</i>							
<i>Analyst_follow</i>	53,685	1.76	2.40	0.00	6.56	0.00	4.44
<i>Ins_holding</i>	53,685	14.48	9.22	0.00	26.72	0.00	21.31
<i>Firm_Size</i>	53,685	5.83	2.70	-2.60	12.05	3.82	7.69
<i>Leverage</i>	53,685	0.19	0.22	0.00	1.00	0.02	0.31
<i>PPE</i>	53,685	0.15	0.22	0.00	0.91	0.01	0.19
<i>Market_to_book</i>	53,685	-0.17	1.53	-2.82	4.29	-1.54	0.78
<i>ROA</i>	53,685	-0.05	0.22	-2.67	0.13	-0.06	0.02

Notes: This table summarizes the key descriptive statistics for the sample and variables used in the analyses. The sample spans 2017–2023 and includes 46,303 U.S. firm-quarter observations with conference-call transcripts. This table reports only topics for the full-call sample. Appendix C reports summary statistics for the full set of topics, including industry-specific topics and topics by prepared-remarks and Q&A segments.

Table 3: Public Activism and Conference-Call Thematic Composition

Panel A: Overall Conference Call						
Variables	(1) Boilerplate	(2) Product Market	(3) Pos. Guidance	(4) Strategy	(5) Cap. Allocation	(6) Neg. Guidance
<i>PA_Binary</i>	0.0020*** (0.0007)	0.0005* (0.0003)	0.0013* (0.0008)	0.0008** (0.0003)	-0.0008* (0.0004)	-0.0028*** (0.0008)
<i>Ln_Content_words</i>	-0.0193*** (0.0013)	0.0013*** (0.0004)	-0.0036*** (0.0012)	0.0016*** (0.0005)	-0.0036*** (0.0006)	-0.0064*** (0.0012)
<i>Ins_holding</i>	0.0001* (0.0001)	0.0000 (0.0000)	-0.0000 (0.0001)	-0.0000 (0.0000)	0.0000 (0.0000)	-0.0000 (0.0001)
<i>Analyst_follow</i>	-0.0012*** (0.0004)	-0.0000 (0.0001)	0.0007** (0.0003)	0.0002 (0.0002)	0.0001 (0.0002)	0.0013*** (0.0003)
<i>Market_to_book</i>	-0.0046*** (0.0007)	0.0006** (0.0003)	0.0039*** (0.0006)	0.0007*** (0.0002)	-0.0033*** (0.0004)	-0.0023*** (0.0007)
<i>Firm_Size</i>	-0.0058*** (0.0012)	-0.0010** (0.0005)	0.0044*** (0.0011)	0.0008* (0.0005)	-0.0029*** (0.0006)	0.0043*** (0.0011)
<i>Leverage</i>	0.0084*** (0.0027)	-0.0003 (0.0012)	0.0085*** (0.0023)	0.0007 (0.0010)	-0.0038** (0.0018)	0.0076*** (0.0027)
<i>PPE</i>	-0.0073 (0.0071)	0.0002 (0.0023)	-0.0037 (0.0055)	0.0024 (0.0029)	-0.0020 (0.0039)	-0.0023 (0.0067)
<i>ROA</i>	0.0173* (0.0093)	-0.0014 (0.0036)	0.0492*** (0.0068)	-0.0016 (0.0037)	0.0405*** (0.0056)	0.0106 (0.0091)
Firm FE	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES
Year FE	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES
Observations	46,303	46,303	46,303	46,303	46,303	46,303
R-squared	0.7355	0.6761	0.6239	0.8980	0.6366	0.7364

Notes: This table reports regressions of conference-call topic shares on public activism exposure. The dependent variable in each column is the share of discussion devoted to the indicated topic. *PA_Binary* equals one if at least one public activism event occurs in the same district (by ZIP code) and quarter as the firm's headquarters, and zero otherwise. All specifications include firm and year fixed effects. Standard errors clustered by firm are reported in parentheses. ***, **, and * indicate significance at the 1%, 5%, and 10% levels, respectively.

Table 3: Public Activism and Conference-Call Thematic Composition (continued)

Panel B: Segment-Level Analysis						
Variables	PRE			Q&A		
	(1) Product Market	(2) Boilerplate	(3) Cap. Allocation	(4) Product Market	(5) Pos. Guidance	(6) Neg. Guidance
<i>PA_Binary</i>	0.0007*** (0.0003)	0.0006** (0.0003)	-0.0010** (0.0005)	0.0014** (0.0006)	0.0024* (0.0013)	-0.0013* (0.0007)
<i>Ln_Content_words</i>	-0.0001 (0.0003)	-0.0022*** (0.0006)	-0.0024*** (0.0009)	0.0012 (0.0007)	-0.0121*** (0.0019)	-0.0039*** (0.0009)
<i>Ins_holding</i>	-0.0000 (0.0000)	-0.0000 (0.0000)	-0.0000 (0.0000)	-0.0000 (0.0000)	-0.0001 (0.0001)	-0.0001 (0.0001)
<i>Analyst_follow</i>	-0.0001 (0.0001)	0.0006*** (0.0002)	0.0005** (0.0003)	-0.0000 (0.0002)	-0.0001 (0.0005)	0.0001 (0.0002)
<i>Market_to_book</i>	0.0001 (0.0002)	-0.0006* (0.0003)	-0.0018*** (0.0006)	0.0016*** (0.0005)	0.0030*** (0.0009)	-0.0018*** (0.0004)
<i>Firm_Size</i>	-0.0006 (0.0004)	0.0028*** (0.0005)	-0.0029*** (0.0007)	-0.0008 (0.0007)	0.0062*** (0.0016)	0.0012* (0.0007)
<i>Leverage</i>	-0.0003 (0.0010)	0.0056*** (0.0015)	-0.0048** (0.0024)	0.0008 (0.0019)	0.0059* (0.0033)	0.0007 (0.0019)
<i>PPE</i>	-0.0004 (0.0021)	0.0021 (0.0032)	-0.0029 (0.0052)	0.0004 (0.0036)	0.0049 (0.0076)	-0.0009 (0.0052)
<i>ROA</i>	-0.0038 (0.0025)	0.0028 (0.0022)	0.0289*** (0.0057)	0.0053 (0.0045)	0.0236*** (0.0064)	-0.0045 (0.0038)
Firm FE	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES
Year FE	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES
Observations	46,303	46,303	46,303	46,303	46,303	46,303
R-squared	0.6495	0.8490	0.6569	0.5004	0.4526	0.6538

Notes: This panel reports regressions of segment-level topic shares on public activism exposure. Columns (1)–(3) use prepared-remarks topic shares, and Columns (4)–(6) use Q&A topic shares, as dependent variables. *PA_Binary* equals one if at least one public activism event occurs in the same district (by ZIP code) and quarter as the firm’s headquarters, and zero otherwise. All specifications include firm and year fixed effects. Standard errors clustered by firm are reported in parentheses. ***, **, and * indicate significance at the 1%, 5%, and 10% levels, respectively.

Table 4: Public Activism and Conference-Call Information Quantity

Variables	(1) Ln_Content_words	(2) Ln_Content_words (PRE)	(3) N_Questions (Poisson)	(4) Ln_Raw_words
<i>PA_Binary</i>	-0.0134** (0.0057)	-0.0145** (0.0060)	-0.0261** (0.0105)	-0.0051 (0.0046)
<i>Ins_holding</i>	-0.0007 (0.0005)	-0.0009 (0.0005)	-0.0009 (0.0008)	-0.0000 (0.0004)
<i>Analyst_follow</i>	0.0210*** (0.0030)	-0.0005 (0.0032)	0.0462*** (0.0065)	0.0130*** (0.0023)
<i>Market_to_book</i>	0.0418*** (0.0055)	-0.0028 (0.0062)	0.0761*** (0.0098)	0.0644*** (0.0044)
<i>Firm_Size</i>	0.0920*** (0.0097)	0.0559*** (0.0113)	0.0889*** (0.0167)	0.1282*** (0.0070)
<i>Leverage</i>	-0.0262 (0.0237)	-0.0466* (0.0268)	-0.0342 (0.0393)	0.0071 (0.0180)
<i>PPE</i>	-0.0526 (0.0610)	-0.0507 (0.0626)	0.0279 (0.0926)	0.0580 (0.0445)
<i>ROA</i>	-0.1521*** (0.0465)	-0.1674** (0.0845)	-0.2770* (0.1415)	-0.1410** (0.0584)
Firm FE	YES	YES	YES	YES
Year FE	YES	YES	YES	YES
Observations	46,303	46,303	43,334	46,303
R-squared	0.6948	0.7019	N/A	0.6627

Notes: This table reports estimates of the relation between public activism and conference-call information quantity. The dependent variables are the natural logarithm of content words in the full conference call, the natural logarithm of content words in prepared remarks, the number of analyst questions estimated using a Poisson model, and the natural logarithm of raw words in the transcript. *PA_Binary* equals one if at least one public activism event occurs in the same district (by ZIP code) and quarter as the firm's headquarters, and zero otherwise. All specifications include firm and year fixed effects. Standard errors clustered by firm are reported in parentheses. ***, **, and * indicate statistical significance at the 1%, 5%, and 10% levels, respectively.

Table 5: The Role of Public Activism Intensity and Thematic Allocation

Variables	(1) M&A	(2) Financial Cost	(3) Covid	(4) Boilerplate	(5) Strategy	(6) Neg. Guidance	(7) Macro Environment	(8) Pos. Guidance	(9) Social
<i>Participation_high</i>	0.0013* (0.0007)	0.0005* (0.0003)	0.0123*** (0.0010)	-0.0010* (0.0005)	0.0006** (0.0003)	0.0003* (0.0001)	0.0012* (0.0007)	-0.0015** (0.0006)	-0.0036*** (0.0011)
<i>Ln_Content_words_{i,t-1}</i>	0.0015** (0.0007)	0.0003 (0.0011)	0.0099*** (0.0008)	0.0005 (0.0004)	-0.0018*** (0.0006)	0.0033*** (0.0006)	-0.0093*** (0.0009)	-0.0043*** (0.0011)	-0.0037*** (0.0012)
<i>Ins_holding_{i,t-1}</i>	0.0001*** (0.0000)	-0.0001 (0.0001)	-0.0001*** (0.0000)	-0.0000 (0.0000)	0.0000 (0.0000)	0.0000 (0.0000)	-0.0001* (0.0000)	0.0000 (0.0000)	-0.0000 (0.0001)
<i>Analyst_follow_{i,t-1}</i>	0.0000 (0.0003)	-0.0001 (0.0003)	-0.0001 (0.0003)	-0.0003*** (0.0001)	0.0007*** (0.0002)	-0.0002 (0.0002)	-0.0003 (0.0003)	-0.0013*** (0.0003)	0.0007** (0.0003)
<i>Market_to_book_{i,t-1}</i>	0.0034*** (0.0005)	-0.0133*** (0.0007)	-0.0134*** (0.0006)	0.0013*** (0.0002)	-0.0012*** (0.0003)	0.0014*** (0.0004)	-0.0032*** (0.0005)	0.0032*** (0.0005)	0.0041*** (0.0006)
<i>Firm_Size_{i,t-1}</i>	0.0073*** (0.0008)	-0.0072*** (0.0011)	-0.0033*** (0.0008)	-0.0009*** (0.0003)	0.0018*** (0.0006)	-0.0007 (0.0008)	0.0014* (0.0008)	-0.0008 (0.0010)	0.0045*** (0.0011)
<i>Leverage_{i,t-1}</i>	0.0101*** (0.0016)	-0.0068*** (0.0026)	0.0047** (0.0022)	-0.0009 (0.0008)	0.0049*** (0.0014)	-0.0033** (0.0015)	0.0026 (0.0020)	-0.0051** (0.0025)	0.0086*** (0.0023)
<i>PPE_{i,t-1}</i>	-0.0198*** (0.0041)	0.0297*** (0.0069)	-0.0041 (0.0050)	0.0053** (0.0024)	0.0020 (0.0031)	0.0051 (0.0038)	-0.0099* (0.0055)	0.0086 (0.0054)	-0.0041 (0.0055)
<i>ROA_{i,t-1}</i>	-0.0070* (0.0038)	0.0074* (0.0044)	-0.0883*** (0.0094)	-0.0008 (0.0014)	0.0033 (0.0024)	0.0040 (0.0027)	-0.0033 (0.0043)	-0.0064 (0.0039)	0.0255*** (0.0060)
Firm FE	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES
Year FE	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES
Observations	46,303	46,303	46,303	46,303	46,303	46,303	46,303	46,303	46,303
R-squared	0.5042	0.6916	0.5219	0.7900	0.7832	0.7759	0.5040	0.6787	0.5219

Notes: This table reports estimates of the relation between high-intensity public activism and conference-call thematic allocation. *Participation_high* equals one if ZIP-quarter protest participation exceeds the sample median. The dependent variable in each column is the share of conference-call discussion devoted to the indicated topic. All specifications include lagged controls, firm fixed effects, and year fixed effects. Standard errors clustered by firm are reported in parentheses. ***, **, and * indicate statistical significance at the 1%, 5%, and 10% levels, respectively.

Table 6: Public Activism Intensity and Conference-Call Information Quantity

Variables	(1) Ln_Content_words	(2) Ln_Content_words (PRE)	(3) N_Questions (Poisson)	(4) Ln_Raw_words
<i>Participation_high</i>	-0.0149** (0.0060)	-0.0137** (0.0068)	-0.0298*** (0.0113)	-0.0059 (0.0051)
<i>Ins_holding_{i,t-1}</i>	0.0011*** (0.0030)	-0.0005 (0.0032)	-0.0009 (0.0008)	-0.0000 (0.0004)
<i>Analyst_follow_{i,t-1}</i>	0.0427*** (0.0057)	-0.0029 (0.0062)	0.0462*** (0.0065)	0.0130*** (0.0023)
<i>Market_to_book_{i,t-1}</i>	0.0929*** (0.0098)	0.0558*** (0.0113)	0.0761*** (0.0098)	0.0644*** (0.0044)
<i>Firm_Size_{i,t-1}</i>	-0.0274 (0.0237)	-0.0465* (0.0268)	0.0887*** (0.0167)	0.1281*** (0.0070)
<i>Leverage_{i,t-1}</i>	-0.0564 (0.0610)	-0.0506 (0.0626)	-0.0337 (0.0393)	0.0072 (0.0180)
<i>PPE_{i,t-1}</i>	-0.2096*** (0.0744)	-0.1678** (0.0845)	0.0283 (0.0925)	0.0580 (0.0444)
<i>ROA_{i,t-1}</i>	-0.0149** (0.0060)	-0.0137** (0.0068)	-0.2788** (0.1415)	-0.1411** (0.0584)
Firm FE	YES	YES	YES	YES
Year FE	YES	YES	YES	YES
Observations	46,303	46,303	46,303	46,303
R-squared	0.6948	0.6627	N/A	0.7363

Notes: This table reports estimates of the relation between public activism intensity and conference-call information quantity. The dependent variables are the natural logarithm of content words in the full conference call, the natural logarithm of content words in prepared remarks, the number of analyst questions estimated using a Poisson model, and the natural logarithm of raw words in the transcript. *Participation_high* equals one if ZIP-quarter protest participation exceeds the sample median. All specifications include firm and year fixed effects. Standard errors clustered by firm are reported in parentheses. ***, **, and * indicate statistical significance at the 1%, 5%, and 10% levels, respectively.

Table 7: Instrumental Variable Analysis

Panel A: First-Stage Results			
Variables	(1) Ln.Participants	(2) Ln.ESG.Participants	(3) Ln.FIN.Participants
<i>Rainfall</i>	-0.0249*** (0.00728)	-0.0375*** (0.00731)	-0.0491*** (0.0128)
<i>Ins_holding</i>	-0.00361** (0.00147)	-0.00315** (0.00149)	0.000547 (0.00125)
<i>Analyst_follow</i>	0.000129 (0.00661)	-0.00141 (0.00643)	-0.0162*** (0.00596)
<i>Market_to_book</i>	-0.0806*** (0.0147)	-0.0790*** (0.0143)	-0.0515*** (0.0134)
<i>Firm_Size</i>	-0.0790*** (0.0187)	-0.0882*** (0.0190)	-0.0281 (0.0184)
<i>Leverage</i>	-0.0321 (0.0463)	-0.0209 (0.0459)	-0.0708 (0.0444)
<i>PPE</i>	-0.0161 (0.134)	-0.0868 (0.133)	-0.234 (0.149)
<i>ROA</i>	0.273* (0.149)	0.263* (0.143)	-0.0596 (0.0972)
Firm FE	YES	YES	YES
Year FE	YES	YES	YES
Observations	46,303	46,303	46,303

Notes: This panel reports the first-stage relation between rainfall and public activism participation. The dependent variables are the natural logarithm of total participants, ESG-related participants, and finance-related participants. All specifications include firm and year fixed effects. Standard errors clustered by firm are reported in parentheses. ***, **, and * indicate statistical significance at the 1%, 5%, and 10% levels, respectively.

Table 7: Instrumental Variable Analysis (continued)

Panel B: Second-Stage Results for Information Quantity	
Variables	(1) Ln_Content_words
<i>Ln_Participants</i> (<i>IV = Rainfall</i>)	-0.1800* (0.0932)
<i>Ins_holding</i>	-0.00361** (0.00147)
<i>Analyst_follow</i>	0.000129 (0.00661)
<i>Market_to_book</i>	-0.0806*** (0.0147)
<i>Firm_Size</i>	-0.0790*** (0.0187)
<i>Leverage</i>	-0.0321 (0.0463)
<i>PPE</i>	-0.0161 (0.134)
<i>ROA</i>	0.273* (0.149)
Firm FE	YES
Year FE	YES
Observations	46,303

Notes: This panel reports second-stage instrumental-variables estimates of the effect of public activism participation on conference-call information quantity. The dependent variable is the natural logarithm of content words in the conference-call transcript. *Ln_Participants* is instrumented using *Rainfall*. All specifications include firm and year fixed effects. Standard errors clustered by firm are reported in parentheses. ***, **, and * indicate statistical significance at the 1%, 5%, and 10% levels, respectively.

Table 7: Instrumental Variable Analysis (continued)

Panel C: Second-Stage Results for Thematic Composition		
Variables	(1) Social	(2) Strategy
<i>Ln_Participants</i> (<i>IV = Rainfall</i>)	-0.0209** (0.0085)	-0.0206* (0.0124)
<i>Ln_Content_words</i>	0.0048*** (0.0014)	-0.0118*** (0.0023)
<i>Ins_holding</i>	0.0000 (0.0000)	0.0000 (0.0001)
<i>Analyst_follow</i>	-0.0002 (0.0002)	-0.0009** (0.0004)
<i>Market.to.book</i>	0.0022*** (0.0004)	0.0089*** (0.0009)
<i>Firm_Size</i>	0.0009 (0.0007)	0.0021 (0.0015)
<i>Leverage</i>	0.0001 (0.0017)	0.0007 (0.0034)
<i>PPE</i>	-0.0062 (0.0039)	-0.0152** (0.0076)
<i>ROA</i>	-0.0012 (0.0046)	0.0591*** (0.0099)
Firm FE	YES	YES
Year FE	YES	YES
Observations	46,303	46,303

Notes: This panel reports second-stage instrumental-variables estimates of the effect of public activism participation on conference-call thematic allocation. The dependent variables are the topic shares indicated in the column headings. *Ln_Participants* is instrumented using *Rainfall*. All specifications include firm and year fixed effects. Standard errors clustered by firm are reported in parentheses. ***, **, and * indicate statistical significance at the 1%, 5%, and 10% levels, respectively.

Table 8: ESG Activism and Conference-Call Thematic Allocation

Variables	(1) M&A	(2) Strategy Market	(3) Strategy Growth	(4) Covid	(5) Cap. Allocation	(6) Neg. Guidance
<i>ESG_Activism_Binary</i>	-0.0013** (0.0005)	0.0005* (0.0003)	-0.0027*** (0.0009)	0.0011*** (0.0004)	-0.0009** (0.0004)	-0.0034*** (0.0008)
<i>Ln_Content_words</i>	0.0015** (0.0008)	0.0014*** (0.0005)	-0.0146*** (0.0015)	0.0043*** (0.0004)	-0.0036*** (0.0006)	-0.0064*** (0.0012)
<i>Ins_holding</i>	0.0001*** (0.0000)	-0.0000 (0.0000)	0.0000 (0.0001)	-0.0000* (0.0000)	0.0000 (0.0000)	0.0000 (0.0001)
<i>Analyst_follow</i>	0.0000 (0.0003)	-0.0000 (0.0001)	-0.0010*** (0.0004)	-0.0003** (0.0001)	0.0001 (0.0002)	0.0013*** (0.0003)
<i>Market_to_book</i>	0.0034*** (0.0005)	0.0003 (0.0002)	0.0092*** (0.0008)	-0.0020*** (0.0003)	-0.0029*** (0.0004)	-0.0023*** (0.0007)
<i>Firm_Size</i>	0.0073*** (0.0008)	0.0004 (0.0005)	0.0028** (0.0014)	0.0001 (0.0004)	-0.0028*** (0.0006)	0.0043*** (0.0011)
<i>Leverage</i>	0.0101*** (0.0016)	0.0002 (0.0009)	-0.0005 (0.0033)	0.0037*** (0.0012)	-0.0038** (0.0018)	0.0076*** (0.0027)
<i>PPE</i>	-0.0198*** (0.0041)	0.0025 (0.0027)	-0.0150** (0.0073)	0.0015 (0.0028)	-0.0026 (0.0039)	-0.0022 (0.0067)
<i>ROA</i>	-0.0071* (0.0038)	-0.0039* (0.0021)	0.0602*** (0.0100)	-0.0031 (0.0032)	0.0204*** (0.0042)	0.0106 (0.0091)
Firm FE	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES
Year FE	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES
Observations	46,303	46,303	46,303	46,303	46,303	46,303
R-squared	0.5042	0.9130	0.6998	0.5253	0.6361	0.7364

Notes: This table reports estimates of the relation between ESG-related public activism and conference-call thematic allocation using 46,303 firm-quarter observations from 2017 to 2023. The dependent variables capture different dimensions of earnings-call discussion, with the corresponding LDA topic numbers reported in parentheses. Panel A reports results for the full conference call, while Panels B and C report results for the prepared-remarks and Q&A segments, respectively. *ESG_Activism_Binary* equals one if ESG-related protest events occur in the same district as the firm's headquarters, and zero otherwise. Control variables include firm characteristics, including *Market_to_book*, *Firm_Size*, *Leverage*, *PPE*, and *ROA*, as well as ownership and information-environment measures, including *Ins_holding* and *Analyst_follow*. All independent variables are measured at the end of the prior quarter ($t-1$). All specifications include firm and year fixed effects. Variable definitions are provided in Appendix A. Robust standard errors are reported in parentheses. ***, **, and * denote statistical significance at the 1%, 5%, and 10% levels, respectively. Intercepts are omitted.

Table 9: Finance-Related Activism and Conference-Call Thematic Allocation

Variables	(1) Social– Corporate Culture	(2) Strategy– Growth	(3) Boilerplate	(4) Product Market	(5) M&A	(6) Pos. Guidance	(7) Cap. Allocation	(8) Macro Environment	(9) Covid	(10) Strategy– Guidance
<i>FIN_Activism_Binary</i>	0.0013* (0.0007)	0.0035*** (0.0013)	0.0013*** (0.0005)	0.0007* (0.0004)	0.0017** (0.0009)	0.0023* (0.0013)	0.0016* (0.0009)	-0.0022** (0.0009)	-0.0060*** (0.0011)	-0.0025*** (0.0009)
<i>Ln_Content_words</i>	0.0021*** (0.0007)	-0.0146*** (0.0015)	-0.0018*** (0.0006)	0.0013*** (0.0004)	0.0015** (0.0007)	-0.0037*** (0.0012)	-0.0036*** (0.0006)	-0.0043*** (0.0011)	0.0099*** (0.0008)	0.0019** (0.0009)
<i>Ins_holding</i>	0.0001* (0.0000)	0.0000 (0.0001)	0.0000 (0.0000)	0.0000 (0.0000)	0.0001*** (0.0000)	-0.0000 (0.0001)	0.0000 (0.0000)	0.0000 (0.0000)	-0.0001*** (0.0000)	0.0000 (0.0000)
<i>Analyst_follow</i>	-0.0004** (0.0002)	-0.0010*** (0.0004)	0.0007*** (0.0002)	-0.0000 (0.0001)	0.0000 (0.0003)	0.0007** (0.0003)	0.0001 (0.0002)	-0.0013*** (0.0003)	-0.0001 (0.0003)	0.0005*** (0.0002)
<i>Market_to_book</i>	0.0025*** (0.0004)	0.0092*** (0.0008)	-0.0012*** (0.0003)	0.0006** (0.0003)	0.0034*** (0.0005)	0.0041*** (0.0011)	-0.0029*** (0.0006)	0.0032*** (0.0004)	-0.0136*** (0.0005)	-0.0054*** (0.0005)
<i>Firm_Size</i>	0.0016** (0.0006)	0.0029** (0.0014)	0.0018*** (0.0006)	-0.0009* (0.0005)	0.0073*** (0.0008)	0.0046*** (0.0011)	-0.0028*** (0.0006)	-0.0008 (0.0010)	-0.0035*** (0.0008)	0.0015** (0.0008)
<i>Leverage</i>	-0.0010 (0.0015)	-0.0004 (0.0033)	0.0050*** (0.0014)	-0.0004 (0.0012)	0.0101*** (0.0016)	0.0087*** (0.0023)	-0.0038** (0.0018)	-0.0051** (0.0025)	0.0045** (0.0022)	0.0002 (0.0019)
<i>PPE</i>	-0.0057* (0.0034)	-0.0147** (0.0073)	0.0021 (0.0031)	0.0003 (0.0023)	-0.0197*** (0.0041)	-0.0040 (0.0055)	-0.0024 (0.0039)	0.0085 (0.0054)	-0.0046 (0.0050)	0.0084 (0.0053)
<i>ROA</i>	0.0003 (0.0044)	0.0602*** (0.0100)	0.0034 (0.0024)	-0.0006 (0.0030)	-0.0070* (0.0038)	0.0254*** (0.0060)	0.0204*** (0.0042)	-0.0065* (0.0039)	-0.0878*** (0.0094)	-0.0227*** (0.0052)
Firm FE	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES
Year FE	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES
Observations	46,303	46,303	46,303	46,303	46,303	46,303	46,303	46,303	46,303	46,303
R-squared	0.5032	0.6998	0.7900	0.6761	0.5042	0.6786	0.6361	0.5040	0.5675	0.5103

Notes: This table reports estimates of the relation between finance-related public activism and conference-call thematic allocation. The dependent variable in each column is the share of discussion devoted to the indicated topic. *FIN_Activism_Binary* equals one if at least one finance- or economy-related public activism event occurs in the same district (by ZIP code) and quarter as the firm's headquarters, and zero otherwise. All specifications include firm and year fixed effects. Standard errors clustered by firm are reported in parentheses. ***, **, and * indicate statistical significance at the 1%, 5%, and 10% levels, respectively.

Table 10: Political Activism and Conference-Call Thematic Allocation

Variables	(1) M&A	(2) Guidance- Margin	(3) Financial- Cost	(4) Strategy- Growth	(5) Boilerplate	(6) Macro Environment	(7) Covid	(8) Pos. Guidance
<i>POLI_Activism_Binary</i>	0.0027*** (0.0008)	-0.0007* (0.0004)	0.0020* (0.0011)	0.0025* (0.0013)	0.0014*** (0.0005)	-0.0021*** (0.0008)	-0.0170** (0.0084)	0.0033*** (0.0011)
<i>Ln_Content_words</i>	0.0015** (0.0007)	-0.0001 (0.0004)	0.0003 (0.0011)	-0.0146*** (0.0015)	-0.0018*** (0.0006)	-0.0043*** (0.0011)	0.0100*** (0.0008)	-0.0037*** (0.0012)
<i>Ins_holding</i>	0.0001*** (0.0000)	-0.0000 (0.0000)	-0.0001 (0.0001)	0.0000 (0.0001)	0.0000 (0.0000)	0.0000 (0.0000)	-0.0001*** (0.0000)	-0.0000 (0.0001)
<i>Analyst_follow</i>	0.0000 (0.0003)	-0.0001 (0.0001)	-0.0001 (0.0003)	-0.0010*** (0.0004)	0.0007*** (0.0002)	-0.0013*** (0.0003)	-0.0000 (0.0003)	0.0007* (0.0003)
<i>Market_to_book</i>	0.0034*** (0.0005)	0.0006** (0.0003)	-0.0133*** (0.0007)	0.0092*** (0.0008)	-0.0012*** (0.0003)	0.0032*** (0.0005)	-0.0135*** (0.0006)	0.0041*** (0.0006)
<i>Firm_Size</i>	0.0073*** (0.0008)	-0.0002 (0.0004)	-0.0072*** (0.0011)	0.0028** (0.0014)	0.0018*** (0.0006)	-0.0008 (0.0010)	-0.0035*** (0.0008)	0.0046*** (0.0011)
<i>Leverage</i>	0.0101*** (0.0016)	0.0009 (0.0010)	-0.0068*** (0.0026)	-0.0005 (0.0033)	0.0049*** (0.0014)	-0.0051** (0.0025)	0.0047** (0.0022)	0.0086*** (0.0023)
<i>PPE</i>	-0.0200*** (0.0041)	-0.0041 (0.0025)	0.0296*** (0.0069)	-0.0151** (0.0073)	0.0019 (0.0031)	0.0087 (0.0054)	-0.0036 (0.0050)	-0.0043 (0.0055)
<i>ROA</i>	-0.0071* (0.0038)	0.0016 (0.0029)	0.0074* (0.0044)	0.0602*** (0.0100)	0.0033 (0.0024)	-0.0065* (0.0039)	-0.0880*** (0.0093)	0.0254*** (0.0060)
Firm FE	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES
Year FE	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES
Observations	46,303	46,303	46,303	46,303	46,303	46,303	46,303	46,303
R-squared	0.5043	0.7569	0.6916	0.6998	0.7900	0.5040	0.5680	0.6786

Notes: This table reports estimates of the relation between political public activism and conference-call thematic allocation. The dependent variable in each column is the share of discussion devoted to the indicated topic. *POLI_Activism_Binary* equals one if at least one politics-related public activism event occurs in the same district (by ZIP code) and quarter as the firm's headquarters, and zero otherwise. All specifications include firm and year fixed effects. Standard errors clustered by firm are reported in parentheses. ***, **, and * indicate statistical significance at the 1%, 5%, and 10% levels, respectively.

Table 11: PA Type and Conference-Call Information Quantity

Variables	(1) Ln_Content_words	(2) Ln_Content_words	(3) Ln_Content_words
<i>ESG_Activism_Binary</i>	-0.0173*** (0.0059)		
<i>FIN_Activism_Binary</i>		-0.0056 (0.0098)	
<i>POLI_Activism_Binary</i>			-0.0003 (0.0082)
<i>Ins_holding</i>	-0.0006 (0.0005)	-0.0006 (0.0005)	-0.0006 (0.0005)
<i>Analyst_follow</i>	0.0206*** (0.0031)	0.0205*** (0.0031)	0.0205*** (0.0031)
<i>Market_to_book</i>	0.0398*** (0.0057)	0.0398*** (0.0057)	0.0398*** (0.0057)
<i>Firm_Size</i>	0.0911*** (0.0105)	0.0910*** (0.0105)	0.0910*** (0.0105)
<i>Leverage</i>	-0.0245 (0.0253)	-0.0248 (0.0253)	-0.0248 (0.0253)
<i>PPE</i>	-0.0492 (0.0637)	-0.0494 (0.0637)	-0.0490 (0.0637)
<i>ROA</i>	-0.1569*** (0.0515)	-0.1570*** (0.0514)	-0.1569*** (0.0514)
Firm FE	YES	YES	YES
Year FE	YES	YES	YES
Observations	42,115	42,115	42,115
R-squared	0.6983	0.6983	0.6983

Notes: This table reports estimates of the relation between public activism type and conference-call information quantity. The dependent variable in each column is the natural logarithm of content words in the conference-call transcript. Columns (1), (2), and (3) separately examine ESG-related, finance-related, and politics-related public activism. All specifications include firm and year fixed effects. Standard errors clustered by firm are reported in parentheses. ***, **, and * indicate statistical significance at the 1%, 5%, and 10% levels, respectively.

Table 12: Public Activism and Conference-Call Sentiment

Panel A: Overall PA Exposure			
Variables	(1) Ln_Negative_Words	(2) Ln_Negative_Words (PRE)	(3) Ln_Negative_Words (Q&A)
<i>PA_Binary_{i,t}</i>	-0.0379*** (0.0092)	-0.0390*** (0.0122)	-0.0288** (0.0133)
<i>Ln_Content_words_{i,t-1}</i>	0.5365*** (0.0139)	0.3526*** (0.0161)	0.7168*** (0.0210)
<i>Ins.holding_{i,t-1}</i>	-0.0016** (0.0006)	-0.0023*** (0.0008)	-0.0013 (0.0010)
<i>Analyst_follow_{i,t-1}</i>	0.0174*** (0.0035)	-0.0068 (0.0046)	0.0320*** (0.0062)
<i>Market_to_book_{i,t-1}</i>	-0.0762*** (0.0068)	-0.1831*** (0.0097)	0.0427*** (0.0105)
<i>Firm_Size_{i,t-1}</i>	0.0171 (0.0114)	-0.0065 (0.0158)	0.0868*** (0.0190)
<i>Leverage_{i,t-1}</i>	-0.0950*** (0.0281)	-0.1797*** (0.0396)	-0.0518 (0.0495)
<i>PPE_{i,t-1}</i>	-0.0635 (0.0606)	0.1042 (0.0857)	-0.2950*** (0.1052)
<i>ROA_{i,t-1}</i>	-1.2165*** (0.0997)	-2.1178*** (0.1432)	-0.3950** (0.1565)
Firm FE	YES	YES	YES
Year FE	YES	YES	YES
Observations	46,302	46,230	45,082
R-squared	0.6012	0.5345	0.5675

Notes: This panel reports estimates of the relation between public activism and conference-call sentiment. The dependent variables are the natural logarithm of negative words in the full conference call, prepared remarks, and the Q&A segment. *PA_Binary* equals one if at least one public activism event occurs in the same district (by ZIP code) and quarter as the firm's headquarters, and zero otherwise. All independent variables are measured at the end of the prior quarter ($t - 1$). All specifications include firm and year fixed effects. Standard errors clustered by firm are reported in parentheses. ***, **, and * indicate statistical significance at the 1%, 5%, and 10% levels, respectively.

Table ??: Public Activism and Conference-Call Sentiment (continued)

Panel B: Activism Type			
Variables	(1)	(2)	(3)
	Ln_Negative_Words	Ln_Negative_Words	Ln_Negative_Words
<i>ESG_Activism_Binary</i>	-0.0148 (0.0104)		
<i>FIN_Activism_Binary</i>		-0.0295** (0.0143)	
<i>POLI_Activism_Binary</i>			0.0146 (0.0152)
<i>Ln_Content_words</i>	0.5565*** (0.0148)	0.5564*** (0.0148)	0.5565*** (0.0148)
<i>Ins_holding</i>	-0.0013** (0.0006)	-0.0013** (0.0006)	-0.0013** (0.0006)
<i>Analyst_follow</i>	0.0168*** (0.0036)	0.0168*** (0.0036)	0.0168*** (0.0036)
<i>Market_to_book</i>	-0.0513*** (0.0073)	-0.0514*** (0.0073)	-0.0513*** (0.0073)
<i>Firm_Size</i>	0.0190 (0.0118)	0.0189 (0.0118)	0.0190 (0.0118)
<i>Leverage</i>	-0.0817*** (0.0297)	-0.0819*** (0.0297)	-0.0818*** (0.0297)
<i>PPE</i>	0.0409 (0.0642)	0.0410 (0.0642)	0.0406 (0.0642)
<i>ROA</i>	-0.7470*** (0.1068)	-0.7479*** (0.1069)	-0.7470*** (0.1067)
Firm FE	YES	YES	YES
Year FE	YES	YES	YES
Observations	42,114	42,114	42,114
R-squared	0.6237	0.6237	0.6237

Notes: This panel reports estimates of the relation between activism type and conference-call sentiment. The dependent variable in each column is the natural logarithm of negative words in the conference-call transcript. Columns (1), (2), and (3) separately examine ESG-related, finance-related, and politics-related public activism. All specifications include firm and year fixed effects. Standard errors clustered by firm are reported in parentheses. ***, **, and * indicate statistical significance at the 1%, 5%, and 10% levels, respectively.

Table 13: Public Activism and Market Reactions Around Conference Calls

Panel A: PA Exposure and Market Return				
Variables	(1) CAR	(2) CRET	(3) CAR	(4) CRET
<i>PA_Binary</i>	0.0025 (0.0022)	0.0058** (0.0023)	0.0025 (0.0023)	0.0062** (0.0024)
<i>Ln_Content_words</i>	0.0010 (0.0021)	0.0012 (0.0021)	0.0030 (0.0022)	0.0029 (0.0023)
<i>Ins_holding</i>	-0.0003 (0.0002)	-0.0002 (0.0002)	-0.0003 (0.0002)	-0.0002 (0.0002)
<i>Analyst_follow</i>	0.0007 (0.0009)	0.0003 (0.0008)	0.0007 (0.0009)	0.0007 (0.0009)
<i>Market_to_book</i>	-0.0439*** (0.0018)	-0.0418*** (0.0018)	-0.0520*** (0.0021)	-0.0509*** (0.0022)
<i>Firm_Size</i>	-0.0352*** (0.0023)	-0.0375*** (0.0024)	-0.0410*** (0.0025)	-0.0429*** (0.0027)
<i>Leverage</i>	-0.0118* (0.0064)	-0.0082 (0.0065)	-0.0148** (0.0072)	-0.0112 (0.0073)
<i>PPE</i>	-0.0247** (0.0120)	-0.0359*** (0.0127)	-0.0151 (0.0132)	-0.0330** (0.0140)
<i>ROA</i>	0.5147*** (0.0304)	0.5298*** (0.0314)	0.5121*** (0.0317)	0.5257*** (0.0329)
Firm FE	YES	YES		
Year FE	YES	YES	YES	YES
Industry-Year FE			YES	YES
Observations	41,912	41,912	41,863	41,863
R-squared	0.0979	0.0973	0.1482	0.1478

Notes: This table reports estimates of the relation between public activism exposure and market reactions around earnings conference calls. The dependent variables are cumulative abnormal returns (*CAR*) and cumulative total returns (*CRET*) over the three-day conference-call window. *PA_Binary* equals one if at least one public activism event occurs in the same district (by ZIP code) and quarter as the firm's headquarters, and zero otherwise. Columns (1) and (2) include firm and year fixed effects. Columns (3) and (4) include industry-year fixed effects and year fixed effects. Standard errors clustered by firm are reported in parentheses. ***, **, and * indicate statistical significance at the 1%, 5%, and 10% levels, respectively.

Table 13: Public Activism and Market Reactions Around Conference Calls (continued)

Panel B: PA Type and Market Return						
Variables	(1) CAR	(2) CRET	(3) CAR	(4) CRET	(5) CAR	(6) CRET
<i>ESG_Activism_Binary_{i,t}</i>	0.0053** (0.0024)	0.0094*** (0.0025)				
<i>FIN_Activism_Binary_{i,t}</i>			-0.0036 (0.0033)	-0.0016 (0.0034)		
<i>POLI_Activism_Binary_{i,t}</i>					-0.0015 (0.0033)	-0.0037 (0.0036)
<i>Ln_Content_words_{i,t-1}</i>	0.0010 (0.0021)	0.0012 (0.0021)	0.0010 (0.0021)	0.0013 (0.0021)	0.0011 (0.0021)	0.0013 (0.0021)
<i>Ins_holding_{i,t-1}</i>	-0.0003 (0.0002)	-0.0002 (0.0002)	-0.0003 (0.0002)	-0.0002 (0.0002)	-0.0003 (0.0002)	-0.0002 (0.0002)
<i>Analyst_follow_{i,t-1}</i>	0.0007 (0.0009)	0.0003 (0.0008)	0.0007 (0.0009)	0.0003 (0.0008)	0.0007 (0.0009)	0.0003 (0.0008)
<i>Market_to_book_{i,t-1}</i>	-0.0439*** (0.0018)	-0.0418*** (0.0018)	-0.0439*** (0.0018)	-0.0418*** (0.0018)	-0.0439*** (0.0018)	-0.0418*** (0.0018)
<i>Firm_Size_{i,t-1}</i>	-0.0352*** (0.0023)	-0.0375*** (0.0024)	-0.0352*** (0.0023)	-0.0375*** (0.0024)	-0.0352*** (0.0023)	-0.0375*** (0.0024)
<i>Leverage_{i,t-1}</i>	-0.0118* (0.0064)	-0.0082 (0.0065)	-0.0118* (0.0064)	-0.0082 (0.0065)	-0.0118* (0.0064)	-0.0081 (0.0065)
<i>PPE_{i,t-1}</i>	-0.0247** (0.0120)	-0.0360*** (0.0127)	-0.0250** (0.0120)	-0.0361*** (0.0127)	-0.0247** (0.0120)	-0.0359*** (0.0127)
<i>ROA_{i,t-1}</i>	0.5146*** (0.0304)	0.5296*** (0.0314)	0.5144*** (0.0304)	0.5295*** (0.0314)	0.5145*** (0.0304)	0.5294*** (0.0314)
Firm FE	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES
Year FE	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES
Observations	41,912	41,912	41,912	41,912	41,912	41,912
R-squared	0.0980	0.0976	0.0979	0.0972	0.0979	0.0972

Notes: This panel reports estimates of the relation between public activism type and market reactions around earnings conference calls. The dependent variables are cumulative abnormal returns (*CAR*) and cumulative total returns (*CRET*) over the three-day conference-call window. Columns (1) and (2) examine ESG-related public activism, Columns (3) and (4) examine finance-related public activism, and Columns (5) and (6) examine politics-related public activism. All specifications include firm and year fixed effects. Standard errors clustered by firm are reported in parentheses. ***, **, and * indicate statistical significance at the 1%, 5%, and 10% levels, respectively.

Appendix A Variable Definitions

Appendix A. Variable Definitions

Table A.14 describes the definitions and data sources of the variables used in the paper.

Table A.14: Variable Definitions

Variable	Definition	Data Source
<i>PA_binary</i>	Equals 1 if public activism events occur in the same district (by ZIP code) as the firm's headquarters, and 0 otherwise.	CCC
<i>Ln_PA_Count</i>	Natural logarithm of the number of PA events.	CCC
<i>Ln_Participants</i>	Natural logarithm of the number of participants in PA events.	CCC
<i>ESG_Activism_Binary</i>	Equals 1 if ESG-related PA events occur in the same district (by ZIP code) as the firm's headquarters, and 0 otherwise.	CCC
<i>POLI_Activism_Binary</i>	Equals 1 if politics-related PA events occur in the same district (by ZIP code) as the firm's headquarters, and 0 otherwise.	CCC
<i>FIN_Activism_Binary</i>	Equals 1 if finance- or economy-related PA events occur in the same district (by ZIP code) as the firm's headquarters, and 0 otherwise.	CCC
<i>Topics_k</i>	Proportion of the overall conference call devoted to topic k .	Constructed (raw data from Refinitiv)

Table A.14 continued

Variable	Definition	Data Source
$Topics_k (PRE)$	Proportion of prepared remarks devoted to topic k .	Constructed (raw data from Refinitiv)
$Topics_k (Q\&A)$	Proportion of the Q&A session devoted to topic k .	Constructed (raw data from Refinitiv)
$Ln_Content_words$	Natural logarithm of the total number of content words in the conference-call transcript, excluding stop words.	Constructed (raw data from Refinitiv)
$Ln_Content_words (PRE)$	Natural logarithm of the total number of content words in the prepared-remarks section of the conference-call transcript.	Constructed (raw data from Refinitiv)
$Ln_Content_words (Q\&A)$	Natural logarithm of the total number of content words in the Q&A section of the conference-call transcript.	Constructed (raw data from Refinitiv)
$Ln_Negative_words$	Natural logarithm of the number of negative words in the conference-call transcript.	Constructed (raw data from Refinitiv)
$Ln_Negative_words (PRE)$	Natural logarithm of the number of negative words in the prepared-remarks section.	Constructed (raw data from Refinitiv)
$Ln_Negative_words (Q\&A)$	Natural logarithm of the number of negative words in the Q&A section.	Constructed (raw data from Refinitiv)

Table A.14 continued

Variable	Definition	Data Source
<i>Analyst_following</i>	Natural logarithm of the number of analysts covering the firm.	I/B/E/S
<i>Ins_holding</i>	Institutional ownership percentage, measured as the share of stock held by institutional investors.	WRDS 13F
<i>Firm_Size</i>	Natural logarithm of total assets.	Compustat (ATQ)
<i>Leverage</i>	Total debt divided by total assets, calculated as $(dlttq + dlcq)/atq$.	Compustat (DLTTQ, DLCQ, ATQ)
<i>PPE</i>	Property, plant, and equipment scaled by total assets, calculated as $ppentq/atq$.	Compustat (PPENTQ, ATQ)
<i>Market_to_book</i>	Natural logarithm of market-to-book value, calculated as $\ln(csho \times prccq/atq - lev)$.	Compustat (CSHO, PRCCQ, ATQ, LEV)
<i>CAR</i>	Sum of three-day abnormal returns over the conference-call window $[-1, 1]$.	WRDS Event Study
<i>CRET</i>	Buy-and-hold (compounded) total return over the conference-call window $[-1, 1]$.	WRDS Event Study
<i>Time</i>	Calendar year in which the event occurs.	Compustat (DATADATE)
<i>Industry code</i>	SIC industry code.	Compustat (SIC)

Appendix B. Demographic of Public Activism

Table A.15 describes the top 10 cities that have the most PA events over 2017–2023 in the US.

Table A.15: Top 10 Cities with the Most Public Activism Events

City	Events
New York	12,138
Washington	8,031
Los Angeles	5,048
Portland	2,732
Chicago	2,534
San Diego	2,254
San Francisco	2,164
Seattle	2,008
Philadelphia	1,931

Notes: This table reports the cities with the highest number of public activism events recorded in the sample.

(Figure Figure A.3) describes the sum of public activism events in the US from 2017 to 2023 by states.

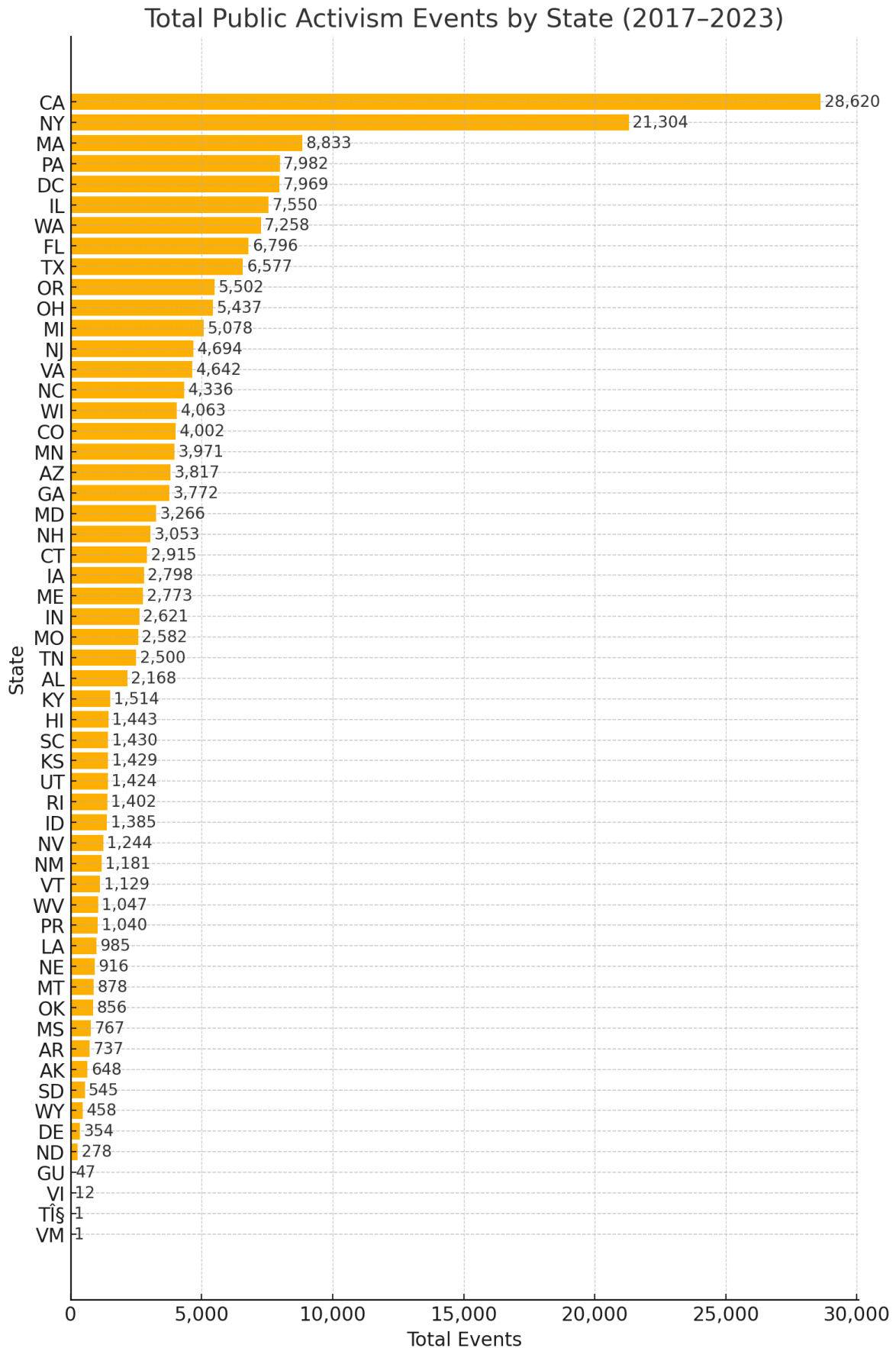


Figure A.3: U.S. public activism events by states, 2017–2023

Note: This figure shows the number of protest events recorded by the Crowd Counting Consortium

Appendix C. Topic Descriptions and Illustrative Excerpts

For each LDA topic used in the analysis, I report the top 10 highest-probability terms in the first section. Each topic’s vocabulary is larger; the 10-term truncation is for exposition only. Because the LDA algorithm does not assign topic labels, I label the topics manually and cross-check them using ChatGPT.

In the second section, I report summary statistics for all topics.

In the third section, I present representative transcript excerpts from both prepared remarks and Q&A to illustrate how public activism (PA) is reflected in conference-call discussions.

I. Top 10 Words of the Topics

This table reports the 10 most frequent words for each sub-topic generated by the LDA algorithm using U.S. earnings-call transcripts from 2017 to 2023.

Table A.16: Top 10 Frequent Words in Each Topic

Hotel Industry (0)	Introduction (1)	Telecom Industry (2)	Social- Corporate Culture (3)	Biotech Industry (4)	Call Opening (5)	Metal Industry (6)	Renewable Energy Industry (7)
hotel	thank	carrier	team	yeah	accelerates	price	battery
property	company	network	great	weight	dive	steel	power
resort	question	fiber	business	loss	thirdly	export	factory
renovation	believe	broadband	company	domain	penetrating	mill	solar
travel	shareholder	wireless	excite	injection	aligns	import	storage
transient	share	cable	people	good_morning	negatively	market	grid
leisure	stock	churn	world	thanks	approximate	increase	module
city	investor	tower	create	pivotal	overview	scrap	installation
group	basically	spectrum	want	variant	formally	cost	cell
owner	report	satellite	build	thank	continual	mexico	energy
Digital Infrastructure (8)	Airline Industry (9)	Meat Export Industry (10)	Industrial Manufacturing (11)	Semiconductor (12)	Uncertainty (13)	Retail Industry (14)	Biotech Industry (15)
cloud	aircraft	international	industrial	tool	sort	store	study
security	airline	internationally	technology	memory	moment	merchandise	patient
data_center	airplane	domestic	equipment	chip	guide	comp	dose
enterprise	flight	market	automotive	wafer	maybe	assortment	data
hardware	pilot	meat	application	node	mean	retailer	trial
workload	american	country	electronics	semiconductor	side	shop	cohort
software	unite	next	manufacture	display	probably	retail	disease
server	corporation	animal	business	foundry	sense	apparel	tumor
cloud	aircraft	international	industrial	tool	sort	store	study
security	airline	internationally	technology	memory	moment	merchandise	patient

Continued on next page

Product Market (16)	M&A (17)	Rubber Manufacturing (18)	Medicine (19)	Restaurant (20)	Medicine (21)	Financial Performance– Revenue (22)	Medicine (23)
product	acquisition	demand	health	restaurant	facility	revenue	procedure
launch	synergy	capacity	health_care	guest	nurse	increase	hospital
market	opportunity	supply	care	franchisees	hospital	agent	surgery
introduce	integration	supply_chain	healthcare	menu	acute	expense	surgeon
marketplace	ebitda	constraint	member	club	outpatient	service	center
introduction	acquire	utilization	employer	food	care	equipment	patient
line	business	inventory	pharmacy	delivery	steven	vessel	physician
able	organic	customer	medical	boat	staff	number	surgical
product	acquisition	demand	health	restaurant	facility	revenue	procedure
launch	synergy	capacity	health_care	guest	nurse	increase	hospital
Strategy– Guidance (24)	Politics– Legislation (25)	Software (26)	Negative Guidance– Market (27)	Strategy– Market (28)	Strategy– Growth (29)	Publication Industry (30)	Real Estate Industry (31)
certainly	process	customer	price	brand	kind	data	property
obviously	work	subscription	business	consumer	mean	trial	asset
term	need	platform	volume	category	definitely	review	lease
comment	utility	enterprise	impact	retailer	maybe	meeting	tenant
question	system	deal	margin	innovation	obviously	approval	portfolio
relate	state	solution	market	retail	side	label	transaction
focus	party	saas	growth	private_label	feel	file	operator
provide	issue	billing	change	distribution	standpoint	submit	real_estate
certainly	process	customer	price	brand	kind	data	property
obviously	work	subscription	business	consumer	mean	trial	asset

Continued on next page

Guidance– Gross Margin (32)	Real Estate (33)	Oil and Gas Investment (34)	Industrial Equipment (35)	Oil and Gas (36)	Biotech Industry (37)	Pharmaceutical Industry (38)	Automobile Industry (39)
customer	lease	contract	backlog	drill	site	molecule	vehicle
fiscal	rent	volume	order	barrel	vaccine	thanks	fleet
supplier	tenant	research_division	margin	basin	study	question	truck
term	square_foot	pipeline	work	permian	infection	generic	engine
base	building	agreement	business	sand	manufacture	data	oems
expect	occupancy	sign	project	acreage	clinical_trial	indication	aftermarket
guidance	space	partner	booking	completion	animal	medicine	electric
revenue	market	compression	book	frac	virus	patent	dealer
customer	lease	contract	backlog	drill	site	molecule	vehicle
fiscal	rent	volume	order	barrel	vaccine	thanks	fleet
Financial– Cost (40)	Digital Media (41)	IT Services (42)	Social– Labor (43)	Homebuilding Industry (44)	Transportation Industry (45)	Strategy– Growth (46)	Theme Park Industry (47)
cost	content	client	labor	home	freight	growth	park
improvement	user	consult	inflation	house	logistics	revenue	theater
improve	video	talent	wage	community	transportation	investment	movie
productivity	platform	service	rate	builder	truck	grow	film
drive	advertiser	business	increase	residential	tariff	solution	event
initiative	advertise	revenue	inflationary	buyer	rail	margin	ticket
margin	subscriber	analytics	environment	land	shipment	business	window
focus	monetization	retention	turnover	price	container	service	attendance
cost	content	client	labor	home	freight	growth	park
improvement	user	consult	inflation	house	logistics	revenue	theater

Continued on next page

Transcript Boilerplate (48)	Transcript Boilerplate (49)	Strategy– Marketing (50)	Agriculture (51)	Water Utilities (52)	Pharmacy (53)	Macro Environment (54)	Covid (55)
people	refinitiv	digital	inventory	water	patient	refinitiv	covid
mean	wwwrefinitivcom_content	consumer	crop	farm	payer	refinitiv_streetevents	pandemic
know	refinitiv_streetevents	channel	season	meter	physician	wwwrefinitivcom_content	state
want	frame_similar	experience	farmer	acre	prescription	supply_chain	safe
probably	consent_refinitiv	drive	grower	land	medicare	right_reserve	reopen
happen	republiation_redistributio	market	weather	west	coverage	frame_similar	precovid
tell	refinitiv_affiliate	brand	seed	river	reimbursement	mean_prohibit	employee
stuff	refinitiv_content	growth	sell	valley	doctor	prior_write	virtual
people	refinitiv	digital	inventory	water	patient	refinitiv	covid
mean	wwwrefinitivcom_content	consumer	crop	farm	payer	refinitiv_streetevents	pandemic
Finance Industry (56)	Government Procurement (57)	Food Production (58)	Banking Industry (59)	Automobile Retail (60)	Advertising Industry (61)	Consumer Electronics Industry (62)	Partnerships (63)
loan	defense	plant	bank	unit	print	device	program
finance	award	fuel	payment	dealer	local	design	development
asset	government	food	merchant	rick	digital	gross_margin	partner
credit	military	gallon	card	retail	station	laser	launch
equity	budget	corn	transaction	brad	radio	product	milestone
mortgage	contract	protein	institution	gross_profit	medium	camera	phase
rate	federal	diesel	deposit	auction	advertise	market	agreement
bond	mission	feed	financial	hurricane	television	smartphone	expect
loan	defense	plant	bank	unit	print	device	program
finance	award	fuel	payment	dealer	local	design	development

Continued on next page

Energy Industry (64)	Pharmaceutical Industry (65)	Covid Downturn and Recovery (66)	Pharmaceutical Industry (67)	Gaming Industry (68)	Positive Guidance (69)	Finance–Capital Allocation (70)	Negative Guidance– Litigation (71)
project	patient	recovery	test	game	business	capital	rate
energy	drug	crisis	testing	sport	growth	cash	plan
coal	treatment	back	instrument	title	strong	free_cash	file
construction	treat	uncertainty	pharma	studio	expect	dividend	settlement
hydrogen	therapy	environment	diagnostics	entertainment	full_year	return	commission
refinery	disease	impact	cancer	player	segment	cash_flow	case
megawatt	physician	recover	screening	franchise	overall	debt	earnings
renewables	label	situation	sample	venue	still	flow	reform
renewable	symptom	pandemic	diagnostic	content	side	shareholder	guidance
project	patient	recovery	test	game	business	capital	rate
Human Resource (72)	Mining Industry (73)	Education Industry (74)					
sale	production	school					
sell	mine	student					
sale_force	gold	math					
salesperson	copper	university					
hire	block	college					
channel	exploration	campus					
account	operation	class					
product	resource	parent					
sale	production	school					
sell	mine	student					

III. Examples of How Public Activism Affects Firms

Table A.17 presents illustrative conference-call excerpts that discuss public activism and related social unrest. The excerpts are intended to provide qualitative context for the empirical findings by showing how managers refer to activism-related developments in earnings calls, either indirectly through broader uncertainty and operating disruptions or directly through effects on store closures, sales, or business sentiment.

Table A.17: Excerpts of Conference Calls Discussing Public Activism

Conference Call	Discussion Example
<i>Q1 2021 Zuora Inc. (Indirect Impact)</i>	“Thank you, Joon. Thank you, and welcome to Zuora’s first quarter conference call for fiscal 2021. Before we begin, let me state, Zuora unequivocally stands with the Black Lives Matter movement. Individually and collectively, we at Zuora stand up against injustice. We condemn intolerance. Systematic racism must be fought. Awareness, understanding, and empathy for these injustices must happen before meaningful deliberate change can occur. Now more than ever, we must support one another as allies.”

Continued on next page

Conference Call	Discussion Example
<i>Q1 2020 Express Inc.</i> <i>(Indirect Impact)</i>	“These are still the early days of the reopening. The new reality is still unfolding. And of course, the protests and riots create even more uncertainty about how things will play out. And to that point, we have had as many as 39 of our stores closed since Saturday, with 8 sustaining damage over the last few days. I’m relieved to report that no Express associates were harmed during these incidents.”
<i>Q2 2020 Twitter</i> <i>(Indirect Impact)</i>	“Q1 saw widespread economic disruption . . . civil unrest. There was a lot happening in June.”
<i>Q2 2020 Target</i> <i>(Direct Impact)</i>	“In areas affected by unrest, we closed locations or reduced operating hours, affecting hundreds of our stores across the country.”

Continued on next page

Conference Call	Discussion Example
-----------------	--------------------

*Q3 2017 Papa John's
(Direct Impact)*

“Now, to the NFL, the NFL is hurting, and more importantly by not resolving the current debacle to the player and owner’s satisfaction, NFL leadership has hurt Papa John’s shareholders. Let me explain. The NFL has been a long and valued partner over the years, but we are certainly disappointed that the NFL and its leadership did not resolve the ongoing situation to the satisfaction of all parties long ago. This should have been nipped in the bud a year-and-a-half ago. Like many sponsors, we are in contact with NFL, and once the issue’s resolved between the players and the owners, we are optimistic that the NFL’s best years are ahead. For good or bad, leadership starts at the top, and this is an example of poor leadership. another year of unexpected decline in viewership of the NFL, combined with significant negative consumer sentiment of our association with the league. These NFL challenges have persisted into Q4, and the negative impact to our projected results has been reflected into our updated full year sales and earnings guidance.”

Continued on next page

Conference Call	Discussion Example
<i>Q2 2025 Byrna Tec</i> <i>(Direct Impact)</i>	“Yes, Matt, thanks for the question. We did see strength during the week where the riots were occurring in Los Angeles, but that’s not surprising. Whenever there is civil unrest, we see much stronger sales. I would say during that week, sales were probably up by 40% versus the prior week. That said, it’s a very transitory trend. It happened that week during the riots and then sales returned exactly to where they were before the riots. You can use 25% to 40%. Last quarter, we were up 41%, slightly more, but I think 25% to 40% is a very good range for the year. So yes, I would work with that. Again, as I said, there is some softness that we’re seeing in the market and that other CEOs that I speak to are seeing in the market; that said, we are growing dramatically in terms of our distribution channel, the number of celebrity endorsers, and the places where you can buy Byrna. So I think even in a softer market, 25% to 40% is a safe bet.”

Appendix D. Event Categorization and Panel Data

I. Data Source and Pre-Processing

I use event-level data from the Crowd Counting Consortium (CCC), which systematically documents U.S. protest events since 2017 using local and national news, verified social media, public submissions, and official records under a transparent coding protocol. For each event, CCC reports the date, location (city, county, state, and latitude–longitude), issue and claim tags, organizational sponsors, participant counts (often with low and high bounds), and source citations.

In the Stata workflow, I conduct the following pre-processing steps:

1. I convert CCC’s daily date string to a Stata date and create year, quarter, and month variables for aggregation.
2. I restrict the sample period to 2017–2023.

II. Event Categorization (Keyword Rules)

PA events are classified using case-insensitive substring matching on the CCC text fields *issues* and *claims* (see Table A.18 for an example). I convert these fields to lowercase and apply a set of keyword rules. Each event is assigned to one label only; that is, the categories are mutually exclusive. The *Other* flag is assigned only when none of the other categories is triggered.

Table A.18: Example of Keywords in Each Category

Claims (CCC)	Issues (CCC)	Label (Constructed)
for voting rights, for Black empowerment, for freedom	civil rights; democracy; racism	Social
for climate action	environment	Environmental
for housing and employment opportunities and medical care for homeless people	economy; healthcare; housing	Economy
against President Trump, against fascism, for democracy	democracy; presidency	Politics
for Palestinian liberation	foreign affairs	Other

Notes: This figure provides illustrative examples of how CCC claims and issue tags are mapped into the constructed event categories. The examples are representative rather than exhaustive.

1. Environmental (*environment*)

An event is flagged as Environmental if *issues* or *claims* contains terms related to environmental protection or resource use. Representative triggers include, but are not limited to: *environment, environmental, climate, forest, animal, water, resource, nature, natural, carbon, solar, pollution, pipeline, powerline, fossil fuels, sustainability, construction, beaches,* and *energy*.

Exclusions and overrides. To reduce false positives from mixed issue tags, I conduct a manual validation pass and prioritize the *claims* text over broad *issues* tags when they conflict. For example, if *issues* lists compound tags such as “energy; healthcare; labor” but the claim reads “for higher pay and better health benefits for United Metro Energy workers,” the event is recoded as Social and *environment* is set equal to zero.

2. Social (*social*)

An event is flagged as Social when *claims* reflects labor or worker issues, civil rights, community safety, or related social themes. Representative triggers include labor-related terms such as *workers, labor, union, collective bargaining, minimum wage, fair wages, fair*

contract, better working conditions, layoffs, hazard pay, strike, and Labor Day; civil-rights language such as *Black Lives Matter, racism, racial equality, racial justice*, LGBTQ-related terms such as *LGBT* and *LGBTQ+ pride*, and women’s rights language; as well as community and consumer issues such as evictions and outsourcing, and firm-specific labor disputes involving companies such as Starbucks or Amazon.

3. Governance (*governance*)

An event is flagged as Governance when *claims* includes terms related to corporate accountability and oversight, such as *executives, CEO, board of directors, transparency, discrimination*, and anti-corruption or oversight language.

4. Finance (*economy*)

An event is flagged as Finance when *issues* or *claims* references macroeconomic or financial topics, including *economy, banking and finance, housing, taxes, taxing, market, economic*, and *rate hikes*.

5. Politics (*politics*)

An event is flagged as Politics when *issues* or *claims* references the presidency, democracy, or other political issues.

6. Other (*other*)

An event is flagged as Other only if it is not flagged as Environmental, Social, Governance, Finance, or Politics. Thus, *Other* is a residual category.

Note: The full script contains a broader set of keywords and phrasings; the examples above are illustrative rather than exhaustive.